her faintly and even now feel a great pain in my heart, when I think of her. She was my sole companion and friend in the forest. She was like a woodland goddess—a mother, whom the forest gave me in the days of great sorrow. It was she, who nourished me from infancy up. I still remember her with the load of woods on her head,—the tropical sun burning overhead and making her perspire all the while. She would approach me with sweet forest-fruits and hand them to me with great affection. At times, she carried me in her arms and walked over the forest-path. If she would miss me for a moment, she would search me madly. Your father carried me from the forest, separating me from her. I do not know how she is bearing her life, parted from me." (L.l 1-44.)

(14)

Kunjalatā.

"What a tale of sorrow have you told me, dear lord! The maiden must have felt a great pain, parted from you. Wherefrom did the unfortunate girl come to live in that wild region? Was there nobody there, whom she could call her own? Has she no parents, no brother, no kinsmen in that forest? She must be wonderfully beautiful, as you praise her so much. I am eager to see a likeness of her handsome figure. Can you not draw her picture and give me an idea of her beautiful face?"

The prince hesitated for a moment and then sat in that nuptial bower to draw the picture of the maiden of the forest. He drew her as he remembered—with her long flowing hair, touching her very anklets. Slowly did he draw her eyes and fine eye-brows, her fair limbs and slender waist, and her breasts soft as the buds of Kadamba flowers.

When Kunjalatā saw the picture of the handsome woman, she spoke thus to her lord, * * * (some lines not found here). (Ll. 1-16.)

(15)

Then did she see her father, the Raja and said to him, " Here is the picture of a woman. I want a maid-servant, like her, so far as possible."

The Raja ordered it to be announced by a beat of drums.

People said that the girl, whom the Raja had appointed as maid-servant for Kunjalatā must be some princess in disguise, so beautiful she was. Some misfortune must have reduced her to this plight. The princess found that the woman was the very forest-maid her husband had painted.

Now her mind became disturbed by conflicting thoughts. " I have perchance brought a crocodile by digging a canal myself. I am to blame for it. She seems to be my natural enemy. Better it was that she lived in the forest. Why have I brought her to the palace ?"

I will tell you the reason of her sorrow. She was at first moved by a spirit of compassion. But now she felt very differently. From the day of her marriage, she was happy with her husband. But now what a change ! Phulkumār slept in the nuptial chamber that night and slowly Kunjalatā approached him. On other days, they talked and laughed together and felt like one soul. But to-day it seemed as if a cloud had covered the moonbeams. The prince looked at Kunja and yet did not glance in the same sweet way. His smiles on other days were always on his lips, but to-day they disappeared too quickly like a flower that bloomed only

to fade away. Perceiving this change in him, the princess became sad in her heart and did not know what she should do.

But Kānchanmālā was happy beyond measure. It was like the acquisition of a great wealth by a poor man, or like the recovery, by a serpent, of the jewel, dropped from its hood.[1] Such was the great joy of Kānchanmālā on getting her husband back. They lived happily, satisfied with a sight of each other, like a pigeon and its mate, living in the same nest—like the cuckoo and its consort, singing the same song of love. If they did not see each other for an hour, they felt pain. They felt this strong bond of love secretly in their hearts.

It so happened afterwards that the prince would not relish any food, unless it was served by Kānchan. He would not be lulled to sleep, if she would not be fanning him. She became indispensable to him in his daily life. The princess perceived that Kānchanmālā had become her *husband's* maid-servant and not *hers*. She was at her wits' end to find out a remedy. More than this, she perceived that when Kānchan slept, the prince stealthily fanned her. Sometimes he secretly peeped through the doorway and intently gazed at her beauty. The princess' heart burnt with anger and jealousy. Now, one day the prince was going on a hunting excursion. He took leave of Kānchanmālā but forgot to say a word of farewell to the princess. (Ll. 1-12.)

(17)

Kunjalatā called Kānchan privately and told her that as her husband had gone away for hunting, she would not like to sleep in her chamber alone but would

[1] It is a tradition in this country that if the serpent with the fabled jewel on its hood, loses it by some chance, it dies of grief.

have her as companion in her room. "We will spend the night happily in sweet conversation and sleep comfortably on our couches."

It was midnight and the stars shone on the sky brightly. Kunjalatā at that still hour of night asked Kānchan to give an account of her past life.

Kunjalatā.

"Your life, dear girl, is shrouded in a mystery. You lived in the forest like a wood-nymph. Who were your parents? Have you no brother? It seems that you are the most unfortunate girl in the world. I feel a curiosity every day to know your past life. But my husband would neither tell anything himself about you, nor allow me to ask of you. He is to-day absent from the house and this is an opportune moment. Please tell me all facts, relating to your birth and past life."

Kānchanmālā was hitherto known to be a prudent girl. But imprudence prompted her to-day and she gave a full account of herself from the very beginning.

She first related her life at Bharāinagar. When she spoke of her parents, often did she wipe away her tears with the edge of her *Sāri*. At this time the clouds roared in the sky and rain fell in heavy drops. The girl could not proceed owing to overwhelming emotions that made her voice choked with tears. Often did she lift her hands to wipe away the growing tears. Anyhow she managed to give an account of her mother and of the mysterious Sanyāsi, who gave her a fruit to eat. Then she related the story of her marriage and how she became the wife of a blind boy at her father's command. Then with tears, which she could not check but fell incessantly like rain, she told what she had sufferred in the forest. She then referred to the kindness and hospitality with which

the woodman and his wife had received her in their home. And last of all, she spoke of the misfortune that befell her. She had gone deep into the recesses of the forest for wood, but on her return did not find her husband at home. For six months had she travelled in quest of him but in vain. Then by the dispensation of Providence, she came to that city. Here she ended her story with a sigh. (Ll. 1-38.)

(18)

She spoke sincerely but her words produced an effect which poisoned her life.

Kunjalatā privately spoke to her mother thus, "O my mother, from you alone I can expect sympathy. Hear what an woe I am suffering from. I felt a great pain in my heart last night. It seems as if a sharp arrow pierced my breast right through." Then she related to her mother the whole story of Kānchanmālā, and ended by saying "A co-wife has come to our house to destroy all my happiness. It is like living in the same house with a venomous snake. Was it ever heard that a woman, living with her co-wife could ever be happy? Even if she sleeps on a soft milkwhite bed a thorn seems to prick her body and though she lives in the midst of the greatest happiness in all other matters, she scarcely feels happy for a moment. Just as the house is burnt to ashes by fire, it is even so by a co-wife. She takes away all the good luck, which otherwise would be her partner's.

Then the mother and daughter laid their heads together to devise means to banish Kānchanmālā to the forest.

At this time, the Raja of that city, Kunjalatā's father, died. Within a few days, the royal elephant, the pride of the stall, also died suddenly. All this had happened before the prince Phulkumār returned from

hunting. A report was somehow in the air before his arrival that a witch had come to that city and all this mischief was her doing.

The prince came back but did not give credit to the rumour. Then the old queen secretly formed plans with her advisers and had the finest horse, belonging to the royal stable, killed one night and besmeared the bed and floor of Kānchanmālā with the blood of the animal. This was shown to the prince as evidence.

Then the report spread rapidly that the King had brought a witch to his palace, who was eating the elephants and horses of the stable. The people were frightened and resolved to leave the city for fear of being devoured by the witch. Thus the prince was compelled to banish the unfortunate Kānchan from the palace.

(Ll. 1-16.)

(19)

A moment's happiness is followed by continued sorrow. This life of ours, alas, is a sad mixture of weal and woe. Now the bright moonbeams light up the sky, but a moment hence, it is darkened by clouds. Like the water-drop on a lotus-leaf, the fortune of a man is unsteady and fickle. For a moment, the drop seems to stand firm on the leaf, but a moment afterwards, it tremulously glides down. To-day a prince, in the height of pomp and power—to-morrow a beggar of the street. To-day a millionaire, to-morrow a pauper. To-day the royal umbrella is spread overhead, to-morrow, a houseless vagabond, he seeks shelter for his head under the branches of a tree. To-day a father of seven children, to-morrow childless, he laments the death of his dear ones. A queen the day before, but an exile in forest to-day.

Be not too proud of your good fortune. One's luck shows the flow and ebb tides, like a river, and constantly changes.

Kānchanmālā.

"Oh my luck, tell me which way I will follow in this forest. Ill-starred am I from my birth. My father drove me away, when a mere child, taking me for an unlucky wretch,[1] and my God, who created me, joined my hands with those of a blind lad. My mother died untimely and I had no brother born. My lot has ever been to wander in the forest, weeping, helpless. If one is doomed to sorrow by Providence, who will, alas, help that one? Queen Sita, when *enceinte*, had to spend her days in the forest, banished from her palace. Ye tigers, that roam in the forest seeking prey, eat me up and get strong by eating human flesh. Ye serpents, that wander in this wild region, relieve me from my misery, once for all, by biting me with your venomous teeth. Death is like life unto me and life, to me, is bitter as death."

So did the unfortunate damsel wander weeping and lamenting in the depths of the forest, but she did not seek out the woodman, her foster-father, lest it should cause him pain to see her condition. Like the river in August, impelled by a strong emotion, she wandered from forest to forest and knew not when the day dawned or when it closed. (Ll. 1-34.)

(20)

Wandering in this way for six months she suddenly recollected the Sanyāsi, who had promised her help at the hour of danger.

[1] This is another instance of anomalous statements. In the beginning of the story it is stated that she left her home of her own accord, disgusted with the flagrant injustice of her father.

She sought the fig-tree for some days and then by chance found it out.

She gently knocked thrice at the tree. The Sanyāsi came out of its cavity.

She was still beautiful and bright as a flame. The holy man instantly recognised her. Kāṅchan fell at his feet and related her whole story, as to how the mother and the daughter had conspired to banish her to the forest. It was all her own fault as she had sincerely confided the story of her life to her co-wife. That sincerity caused her ruin.

The Sanyāsi promised his help, but asked her to wait there for a few days.

She lived in the hollow of the tree for three days. Once when the night was far advanced, she heard a sound like that of the strokes of hundreds of axes and felt as if many hands were employed in cutting down the woods of the forest. Each night she heard the sound and once in the depth of night, she came out of the cavity and saw ploughs made of gold and of silver. Bears and tigers were yoked together for driving the plough. Unnumbered labourers had assembled there and were constructing a city in the wood. A large number of palaces and houses were built there.

Nine days and nine nights passed in this way, after which the Sanyāsi called Kāṅchanmālā to his presence and showed her the city that was built there. She was surprised to see the city, which not only surpassed, in grandeur, Bharāinagar, the home of her father, but the one that belonged to Kunjalatā's father. She had travelled through many places in search of her husband, but nowhere had she seen a city like that.

The Sanyāsi proclaimed, by beat of drum, that a new city was built, of which the mistress was beautiful as a

golden statue. "She will herself elect her husband at a public Durbar and desires princes to come and become suitors for her hand." Through seven big cities, the proclamation was made by beat of drums. Seven young princes of the seven cities came to sue her hand, with their retinue and attendants. But none of them could satisfy her conditions and win her.

The princess Kānchanmālā, the mistress of the city, knew a song. Half of it she would sing. The other half must be recited by the person, who wished her hand. This was her condition. The seven princes returned home disappointed. (Ll. 1-20).

(21)

Then came a blind beggar. He was so weak that he had to walk with the help of a stick. He stood at the gate of Kānchan's new palace and begged alms, saying "O princess of the new city, I have heard a good deal about your wealth and liberality." So saying, he stood at the gate.

The princess saw the beggar from her balcony. Though blind, the beauty of his person was dazzling to the eyes. She filled a golden plate with alms and herself came there to offer it to the beggar. He had long hair and his beard had grown, as he had not shaved it for many days.

"Where do you live, poor man, and where would you go at the end of the day?" asked Kānchanmālā.

The Beggar.

"I have heard your proclamation. I am not here for begging alms. That was a mere pretext for having an opportunity of talking with you. But, maiden, will you sing the song, of which the remaining portion you want

your suitor to complete. And I ask you this question, if I can satisfy your condition, will you be ready to marry me?"

Kānchan had to sing her song. She sang of her early life,—how she was born, and how she had to marry a blind boy, how, by the grace of a Sanyāsi, the boy gained his sight and how she passed her life in the forest in the house of a wood-cutter—how that husband was carried away and how, after long wanderings, she at last found him and how the princess, with her mother, plotted against her and had her banished as a witch.

Here she stopped and said that so far she knew the story. He who will be able to relate events that occurred after this, shall win her for a wife, according to her vow.

The beggar said, "I will, with your permission, sing the rest of the song." (Ll. 1-34).

(22)

"Having banished his forest-queen, the prince became mad with grief. He had no desire for food or drink and one night left his palace. He cared not for his kingdom—nor for his throne. He cared not for Kunjalatā, his beloved wife, nor for the golden couch on which he slept. He left his army, retinues and escorts and wandered about in quest of Kānchanmālā, like a mad man. He is still wandering and his eyes are now blind with constant weeping." (Ll. 1-10.)

(23)

The blind beggar was none other than Prince Phulkumār himself. They recognised each other and Kānchan offered her whole-hearted services to her blind husband. She washed his feet and wiped them with her own dishevelled hair. Thus did she pass her days in great sorrow.

Six months passed and Kānchan had not seen the Sanyāsi all this time. He returned after six months and Kānchan told him her sad tale. She said, "Once you helped me at a critical hour of my life. Now be pleased again to restore sight to my husband." Saying this with a look of entreaty and appeal, did she clasp the feet of the Sanyāsi.

"Once you cured my husband's blindness. I am grateful to you. You can sympathise with a wife's grief. My happiness of life entirely depends on my husband. I do not care for my own self. I seek no other boon at your hands than what will promote my husband's happiness. Restore him his eyesight. I do not care for this kingdom, nor for wealth and pomp. Once I lived with my husband in the forest and I am prepared to do so again."

The Sanyāsi said, "I once cured your husband of his blindness. Why should you again and again trouble me in this way?"

The girl said weeping, "It is because you held out the promise that whenever I would be in distress, I should come to you for help. And what misfortune, revered Sir, can be greater than mine? Where is a woman whose sufferings are greater than mine? I do not crave wealth or kingdom. Take away my own eyes, if you will. I shall be glad to bear the life of the blind. But restore sight to my husband." (Ll. 1-16.)

(24)

The Sanyāsi.

"Then accept my condition, and swear that you will act accordingly, whatever it may be.

"You will have to leave this city this very night. You will have to leave your husband for ever. No more

in life will you be permitted to see him. Then and then only shall your husband be restored once more to his vision. You should not, moreover, leave him with a sigh. With a perfectly tranquil mind, you will have to make this renunciation. On this condition alone, I can cure your husband. But hear something more. The princess Kunjalatā is here. She is a wanderer in this forest in quest of her husband. Now make a gift of this lovely city and your husband to the co-wife, with a mind not at all disturbed."

When Kānchan heard this, she burst into loud sobs.

It is the garden which adorns a house. The woman looks lovely when she has a child in her arms. The lotus adorns a tank and the land is beautiful, when flowers bloom on it. The flourishing kingdom gladdens the heart of a king and the store, which is full of wealth, becomes a coveted treasure. It is the lamp that illuminates the dark spot and it is the crown that adorns the head of a prince. Like all these and even more, is the husband prized by a devoted and chaste wife. If a boat is left by the helmsman, it sinks into the whirlpool of a river. The parents do not care for the daughter after her marriage and if the man, with whose hands she joins hers, gives her up what would her beauty avail her? Who will, alas, preserve the honour of a woman, deserted by her lord? To her, death and life are the same.

She lamented in this way and then wiped her tears away. Then she said in a calm and firm tone, "Yes, cure my husband's blindness. I will go away from him and from this place for ever." (Ll. 1-34.)

(25)

Then the Sanyāsi asked Kānchan to follow him till she reached anothor fig-tree. He gave three strokes to the

tree with his fingers and from the cavity of it, came out a woman. Kānchan saw that she was the princess Kunjalatā, her co-wife. The Sanyāsi gave a fruit to Kānchan, saying that her husband would be cured of his blindness on eating the fruit, but ordered her first to offer the fruit to the princess.

The Sanyasi.

"Though painful the condition, make yourself ready to fulfil it, without feeling any pain. With this fruit give your husband to Kunjalata. Make your mind firm, so that you may not feel any pain in this act of renunciation. If, however, you give this fruit, with the least sorrow in your heart, your husband will not be cured."

Then did Kānchanmālā with a great effort rise above the level of ordinary human beings and forget all about her own happiness and sorrow. With the fruit in her hand, she stopped a moment to collect herself and then she gave it to her co-wife, together with her husband and kingdom. No one saw a tear in her eyes. Nor did her heart beat but once in sorrow. She left her husband with a tranquil mind. Lest her tears should, in the least, interfere with her husband's cure, she gave up all sorrowful thoughts, and unmoved in her mind, she made the great gift.

It is the hardest of all trials, from which she came out a victor. Though she was a feeble woman, she could

do so. Even the strongest of men could hardly cope with a situation like this.* (Ll. 1-18.)

* A friend is telling me that Kāanchan's renunciation resembles that of Gilliatt in Victor Hugo's 'Toilers of the Sea' where the hero made a sacrifice worthy of the Bengali ballad's heroine. But I cannot agree to this. With my great respect for the high character and devotion of Gilliatt, I should say that he did nothing wonderful by giving up his claims on Déruchette. She had no love for Gilliatt,—not only so, Gilliatt found positive proof of her great dislike for him and actually saw her in the arms of Caudray whom she loved with her whole heart. What sane man would care to marry such a girl ? Here in the Bengali ballad love is mutual and genuine and this makes the renunciation glorious and real. Gilliatt certainly suffered greatly for love, but his renunciation was forced, and cannot therefore be compared to the sacrifice made by Kānchan who gave her husband to her co-wife, knowing that he was attached to her and not to her co-wife. She thus performed an act of great sacrifice, simply wishing the good of her husband—a sacrifice which showed the greatness of her love, no less than the high ethical sense which inspired her action.

Another Version.

(26)

When Kanchan was about to depart, the Sanyasi said, "Go to your father's city. You were banished from Bharāinagar at the contrivance of your step-mother. She is a witch. Take this magic-rod with you. She has devoured many men and women of your father's city. As soon as you will arrive at your father's palace with this rod, she will fly away in terror, and your father will be free from her charms."

Kānchan did as she was directed and released her father from the influence of the witch. Then the ministers and other officers of her father advised him to look after a suitable bridegroom for Kānchan.

But there was a hindrance to this proposal. In the countryside they talked about Kānchan's absence from the palace for a long time. How could it be known that she had led a chaste and virtuous life? The wise heads assembled in the palace and expressed an opinion that there should be an ordeal to test her chastity.

A long cobweb should be thrown up in the air and Kānchan must steadily hang in the sky, catching hold of it. If she succeeds, it will then be known that Kānchan is a chaste woman. The report of the coming ordeal was trumpeted out all over the country and princes and potentates from the neighbouring cities came there to behold it. In this assemblage of noble men was Phulkumār, her husband, who had come there with Kunjalatā.

Kānchanmālā.

"I bid adieu to you, my esteemed father. Your unfortunate girl would no more be a source of trouble to you; and O my father's ministers and officers, to you, also, I bid a farewell. No more will you have to counsel my father as to the right path about his daughter. I call upon you to be witnesses, O sun and moon, night and day, as to what sort of woman I am. I do not know what is right or wrong, what is vice and what is virtue.

Now farewell, O Kunjalatā, my dear sister. I leave, in your custody, my own husband, far dearer than life.

And you, my dear husband, the true lord of my heart are you. I bid adieu to you. Return to your city with Kunjalatā. Do not, I pray, feel any pain for me. A hundred times do I bow to you, before final separation. Try to forget me in your whole-hearted love for Kunjalatā.

O princes and kings, who have assembled here, I pay my respects to you, before I depart. The period of curse is over. I have passed my twentieth year."

So saying, she slowly caught hold of the fine thread of cobweb, which her father's men had thrown up in the sky and began to climb up till she completely disappeared from the sight of all.

Like a room, where the light is put out, the whole palace became dark for a time at her disappearance. The citizens of Bharāinagar lamented for one, who had been born of a heavenly spark and disappeared like a heavenly spark. (Ll. 1-32.)

SANTI

PREFACE

The ballad 'Santi' was collected by Munshi Jasimuddin in February, 1925, from an illiterate Mahomedan, named Esem Khan, aged 50, of Pearpur in the district of Faridpur (E. B. R.).

It contains a hundred and fifty lines and the rules of rhyme are disregarded in many of them, though the metre of the ballad seems to approach the 'Payar'—the familiar measure of versification, generally adopted by our country-bards.

Though the song has been preserved by Muhammadan rhapsodists for some generations past. It is essentially a Hindu-tale, originally composed by a Hindu poet.

The author's name is Jaidhar Bania. We have found several versions of this ballad and in some of them the name of the poet is given in the colophon. In one version the name of the heroine is given as Lila, instead of Santi. But as there is a general agreement in the details of treatment, these various varsions seem to be the offshoots of the one and the same Ballad, changed in places by the village-singers.

It is an exquisite ballad, inspite of its rugged and irregular rhyming. The old ballad-makers may be at times crude but never verbose. This ballad, in the form of a dialogue, is more suggestive than elaborate, and oftentimes leaves gaps which the reader must fill up by the suggestions of the stanzas, for appreciating the consistent beauty of the tale as a whole. He must, for instance, discover, closely reading between the lines, that the husband of Santi, who makes his appearance at the end

of the ballad, is none other than the person who tried to entice her away during all the twelve months of the year by temptations and threats. If this is not understood, the interest and the beauty of the ballad will be considerably missed. It is clear from the dialogue that the husband of Santi married her years ago and went abroad for trading purposes. She was a mere child at the time of marriage. Her husband returned when she grew up and became a woman. Like most of the Hindoo wives, she instinctively felt the sacredness of marriage-vow and knew that her life was dedicated to her husband, even before she could have any opportunity of forming an intimacy with him. The usual custom with a young married girl in this country is that after the night of marriage, she spends eight, or sometimes ten days, called *Astamangal* or *Dasamangal*, as the case may be, in her husband's home and then returns to her father's home, where she remains until she comes of age. The husband of Santi returned after many years. The girl had merely vague memories about the marriage and could not recognise her husband. He wanted to put her character to a test and, disguising himself as a stranger, tempted her during each of the twelve months of the year in various ways. She was modest and courteous, but strongly rejected his overtures. She did not strut and fret at the insult of this offer of love, as a loyal woman of a more violent temper would do. But her replies, couched in clever words, oftentimes bordering on pleasant humour, showed the unrelenting strength of her character that raised her far above the level of ordinary women. Though outwardly she showed a bit of coquettishness, it only served to show the lovely spirit in her of being able to enjoy pleasantries, without affecting the dignity of her character in the least.

Then after the long and protracted trial of twelve months comes the stranger's profession that he is no other than her husband. She is staggered at the report suspecting foul play again. She hangs down her head, not fully knowing what she should do. She puts to him question after question as she has no distinct memory about her husband and his parentage. But when, on a reference to her own parents she is fully satisfied, then does the glow return to her cheek, and she sits with her toilet-box, robing herself in the best of her bridal attire to receive her husband.

We have had many occasions to remark that each of the twelve months of Bengal has some distinctive feature, peculiar to its own. Some particular flower that blooms, some gay bird that sends its high notes to the skies, not to speak of the festivities bearing pleasant associations, mark out the passing away of a particular month and the advent of the next. These Bāramasi songs are peculiarly Bengali, as the clearly defined climatic features of a particular season and its parts are scarcely found so distinctly anywhere in India outside Bengal. They lift up the veil from the face of Nature, showing her sometimes as smiling with sunshine or blooming flowers, and at others, casting her angry looks through her lightnings and clouds. The joyous flood, the *shāli* rice, the boat-race, the bloom of *Mallikā* and *Keoā* flowers, the Durga Puja, the Manasā Puja and other festivities, the gay note of the cuckoo and the shrill song of the *Papia*, the mists that shroud the early mornings or the genial sun-light that brightens them, are associated with particular months, and the *Bāramashis* have an exclusive Bengali charm, which the country-poets are never weary of describing. This ballad will recall some of the passages of Shakespeare's Venus and Adonis. It may be held in contrast

with the famous Spanish ballad, "The ill-married Lady," which gives the tempter a nobler character than the husband. The sacredness of conjugal love carries a great weight with the rural-poets of Bengal and it would be inconceivable to them how adultery and libertinism could be elevated to an æsthetic plane in the name of art, as we find it to be the case in the Spanish ballad. The art that makes attempts at brushing aside the claims of the husband, elected by the woman herself, and sketching on the canvas a second figure, her next choice, cannot carry a high value, æsthetic or artistic, in the soil of India, where true love is another name of life-long devotion. "La bella mal maridada," the favourite Spanish ballad in Sepulveda's collection, will appear shocking to Bengal peasantry, inspite of the appeal it bears in its concluding lines. Yet this Bengali ballad is as fresh as a flower just blown, without any conventional element in it. The date of the ballad is unknown; but it carries the stamp of the age when the school of free love flourished in Bengal—when the spirit of Sahajiya had a strong hold on Bengali youths—before the austere Brahminic renaissance doomed our womankind to stern ordinances, declaring that a young woman's path was not one of rosy dalliance but the secluded domestic chamber, where music was forbidden and where she was not even privileged to listen to a song of the cuckoo, lest it gave rise to some unholy thought. Another version of this ballad is published in Part II in which the heroine is named Lila. It bears in the colophon the name of Jaidhar Baniya as its author. I have got from Sylhet a quite different version published by one Md. Ashraf Hossain who calls Jaidhar a native of Sylhet. Jaidhar Baniya does not seem to be the original poet; he may be a mere recensionist.



"False ! It is the virtuous King who has dug the tank and made its landing ghat for public use." P. 123.

Santi

(1)

"Sweet October has come, sweet is the milk in unripe *āman* rice. My mind is restless, O Sānti, as I behold thy youthful charms."

"Calm thy restless heart and quiet thy soul, O lad, to-morrow at dawn shall I go to yonder landing-ghat all alone and meet you there."

"Neither am I a physician, lad, nor versed in the sacred lore; a simple village-girl, daughter of Guno of the Baniya-caste am I. If indeed you suffer from a malady, how can I cure it?"

(2)

"You are filling your pitcher, girl, go on doing so. But know that I am in charge of the tank and guard it here."

"False! It is the virtuous king who has dug the tank and made its landing-ghat of stone for public use. I, the girl Santi, am filling my pitcher from the tank. I do not believe thee and care not for any guard."

"You have deceived me, O Santi, all these days of November by your glib tongue. My hopes have evermore remained unfulfilled. Behold with new charms on the landscape, November has made its appearance."

(3)

"In this sweet November thou lookest like a silvery streak of moon-beams; O, do not vanish away, but allow me, a stranger, to be revived by a sight of thee."

"Night is coming. I must take care that my mother-in-law may sleep in comfort. Know me, O youth, to be the darling of my husband. I hold a stranger like you in the light of a father or brother."

"This month, too, thou hast deceived me by your glib tongue. Behold the change on the fair face of Nature, announcing the advent of December."

(4)

"It is December now and hear my vow. I will enter your sleeping room at the end of the night and get by stealth what I cannot get as a gift."

"A hundred candles will I keep burning in my room to-night, and at the gate our elephant, Gajamati, will keep watch."

"I will blow out all your hundred candles, and the elephant Gajamati will I kill at your gate by the force of my arms."

"I will cover my bracelets with the edge of my *sadi* lest they jingle, and, sword in hand, shall I keep watch all night. If, at the end of night, the thief is caught, this is my vow that I shall sacrifice him at the altar of the goddess Chandi."

"This month too, Santi, you have deceived me with your glib tongue. With a change in the landscape has January made its appearance."

(5)

"It is January. Look, dear one, the *sadi* you wear is too short. Spread its flowing end as far as you can and receive the humble present of sweet betels and nuts that I have brought for you."

"Take away these presents, I do not want them, lad. You have an elder sister at your house, present these to her, if you like."

"Cruel words hast thou spoken, O Santi. The presents I mean for *you*, and you wish them to be given to my sister! You cause pain to my heart by saying so. Now for all these days of January you have played

cunningly with me, deferring my hopes from day to day. Behold February shows itself with all its new and beauteous colours in Nature."

(6)

"It is February. The nights are long. If on such a night a guest comes to your door, what will you do to receive him?"

"A couch and sofa will be spread for him in the outer room; soft pillows will be given to make his sleep easy and sound. He will have fine rice and pulses for his meals and a blanket will be given him to make the wintry night warm."

"You have beguiled me, dear girl, with your glib tongue this month also. My hopes remain unfulfilled evermore. Behold the approach of March, bringing an array of fresh charms to the landscapes around."

(7)

"It is March. The heat is scorching. Thy beauteous and youthful figure, O Santi, burns my heart with a desire, which I know not how to allay."

"A bad mother gave birth to you, wicked youth, and your father was a wretched eunuch. If there is heat in your body, why not jump down into yonder river and cool your body's heat therein."

"This month is also gone, O Santi. You have deceived me by your glib tongue and withheld the fulfilment of my hopes. On the fair face of Nature have bloomed forth new beauties announcing April."

(8)

"It is April now. Like the sweet layer of cream over milk is your lovely youth, O Santi! but what purpose does it serve, if like a miser, you guard your treasure from others."

"My youth is not a water-melon to be cut to pieces for distribution at dinner. Nor is it the milk of a woman's breast for feeding her babe."

"O cunning one, this month is also gone and you have beguiled me by your glib tongue. I pine with unfulfilled hopes. Behold the new charms of the landscape, indicating the approach of May."

(9)

"It is May. The mangoes are ripe in yonder grove; plenty of these fruits, besides jacks and black-berries, have I brought as my humble present for you."

"Keep these aside, lad, I do not want them. Go home and present them to your sister."

"Cruel are your words, O Santi, these presents are made to you and you cause pain to my heart by your refusal. This month has also gone and my hopes are ever-more deferred. Look at the change of landscape, announcing June."

(10)

"It is June, O Santi, behold the flood in rivers. Near Kanchanpur in the swelling stream has your husband been drowned on his way home."

"False! Had my husband died in the swelling stream near Kanchanpur, the chignon on my head would have been unloose of itself. The pearl-necklace on my breast would have been unstrung, the shell-bracelets in my hands, known by their pet names, *Ram and Laksh-man* would have been broken and the brightness of the red sign of luck on my forehead would have slowly faded away. I believe in these signs and not in your reports, O false lad."

"This month, also, hast thou beguiled me by thy glib tongue. My hopes are unfulfilled and I am joyless.

Behold, on all sides, July's advent is proclaimed by a change in the landscape."

(11)

"It is July. The muddy knee-deep water is seen everywhere. When passing from one house to another through this watery path, you will be served with some gentle strokes from my stick of twigs as punishment."

"Beat me as hard as you can with your stick, O lad. Kill me and float my body in the river. But know, still I will not go to a stranger's house."

"This month, also, hast thou beguiled me by your glib tongue, and my hopes remain unrealised. Behold Nature wears a new apparel at the advent of August.

(12)

"It is August. The rivers are full. I will give you a boat, rowed by sixteen men for playing race in this pleasing season."

"Give your boat to your sister or to your mother, or to those who care for your presents. I do not value them."

"This month, too, you have beguiled me by your cunning words. Nature now has changed her scenes and announces September."

(13)

It is September. In every house the divine mother Durga is worshipped.

"Look at me closely, O Santi, I am here, thy own dear husband, returned home after long days. Don't you know me, dear?"

Santi bowed her head down at these words. "Swear by God," she said, "and speak the truth."

"Which is your native city? What is your name, O youth? And who are your parents?"

"I am a native of Bāhātiā. There I own a house of my own. My father is a Kalpataru and my mother's

name is Ganeswari. I married you, O Santi, years ago, on the fifteenth of an October. The pet name, by which I am called, is Killan Sadāgar."

"If really art thou the dear one of my heart, be pleased to stay here a while. I will return instantly after enquiring of my parents if your account is true."

(14)

"O, my old father and O, my dear mother, what are you busy with, at this moment? Will you tell me to whom you gave me, your daughter, taking the due sum of money?"

"You have passed your twelfth year, and now stand on the threshhold of youth. Is it the inclination, natural to your age, that makes you discover a husband at the gate?"

With a lamp in hand and a *toka* on his head, the old man walks in slow pace to see if really the son-in-law has come.

"It is he, O Santi, no doubt, it is he. Go, receive him. He, the jewel of your heart, has been found at last. Now open the chest, containing your dresses and ornaments. Find out your hair-comb of mica and articles of toilet."

Santi divided her hair into two lovely rows and made a chignon, over which she spread garlands of *champā* and *parul* flowers. She put a *tiara* on her head and wore the *chandrahar* and a waist-belt of the moon-pattern. From her neck hung a lovely necklace. She wore armlets on her arms and bracelets on her wrist. Anklets jingled on her feet and a string of the largest pearls she wore on her breast. Her eyes she beautified with the black *kajjal*-dye, and to finish all, she put, on her forehead, the red mark of luck.

See how bright and lovely she looks to-night, as she softly treads the ground to go to the nuptial room to receive the husband of her heart.

THE TALE OF BHELUA, THE BEAUTIFUL ONE.

PREFACE.

The Ballad of Bheluā is complete in five parts. The first part describes the journey of Madan, the young merchant of Sankhapur, to Kanchannagar by ship for trade. There he falls in love with Bheluā, daughter of Manik, a rich merchant of that place. This love develops into an intrigue and Madan returns home in a very distressed state of mind, owing to separation from his beloved. He communicates the story of the love to his friends, so that his father gradually comes to know of this affair. He sends a match-maker to Kanchannagar, proposing the marriage of his son with Bheluā. Her father, however, rejects the proposal, on the ground of Madan's inferior social status.

The second part deals with another visit of Madan to Kanchannagar and his absconding with Bheluā. He returns to Sankhapur with her, but Murāri, his father, gets angry at his misbehaviour and turns him out from his palace. Madan goes with Bheluā to Rangchāpur on Sylhet-border and settles there, securing, for the time being, the good will of Abu Raja, a cruel tyrant who reigns supreme at the place.

In the third and fourth parts, we find Abu Raja plotting against Madan and sending him away to a foreign country on some pretext. He carries away Bheluā to his palace by force. Bheluā flies to the Jaintia hills, in obedience to her husband's wishes, expressed at the time of parting, and seeks shelter at the hands of the merchant Hiran, a friend of Madan. But the friend

becomes enamoured of Bheluā and woos her hands. She escapes from his city with the help of Hiran's sister, Menakā, and meets Madan, while journeying by river. But being pursued, on all sides, by the ships of Raja Abu and of her own kinsmen, Bheluā finds no other way of escape than by throwing herself into the river. Menakā, the sister of Hiran, who was on another ship, sees this and follows her friend, with a view to save her life. They are about to be drowned. Madan, also, shares a similar fate, trying to rescue them.

An old merchant discovers the fair ladies, with their lives almost extinct, on a shoal in the Chou Gangā (*lit.* the junction of four rivers). By his care they are restored to life, but the good old merchant while trying to find out the city of Bheluā's parents, falls at the hands of the marauding pirate, Abu Raja, who sieges the girls and carries them home, sending away the old man in a shattered boat from Rangchāpur, after having robbed him of his fourteen ships, laden with merchandise.

In the last part, the adventurous expedition of Madan, aided by the ingenuous contrivances of Bheluā and her friend, Menakā, is described in detail, ending in Bheluā's happy union with Madan, who marries her with the consent of her father and inflicts an adequate punishment on the wicked Abu Raja, by leaving him on a wild and desolate shore, bound hand and foot, to be starved to death. Madan not only marries Bheluā but also Menakā, both having been, from the beginning, bound by vows of sisterhood and love for Madan.

This Abu Raja might have been a real historical figure, though the folk-tales of the country have evidently contributed a good deal to the development of this story in its present shape.

Though the poetical value of this ballad is not much, there are many points which would make up for the scholar's toil, if he could patiently read the whole. The origin of the tale must be traced to some incident, which occurred in a remote period, when the Bengalis were celebrated for their commercial activities overseas. The account of profuse gold and jewels, employed in decorating houses and ships, to be found in this poem, gives us glimpses, through much exaggerations and crude rustic conventions, into the condition of our country, which literally teemed, at the time, with untold wealth. No doubt it was a report of such proverbial riches of the Orient spread afar in the West, which made Milton sneeringly refer to the 'barbaric' gold and pearls of the East in his Paradise Lost.

On the treacherous banks of the great rivers of Eastern Bengal, it was not safe to undertake masonry works on a large scale, but wealthy people built artistic bungalows, spending fortunes over their decorations. To this point I drew attention in my introduction to the first volume of the Ballads. In this ballad very graphic descriptions are given of such bungalows, with four and sometimes eight slanting roofs. The houses were so spacious that often a hall contained fifty-two doors (Text, page 143, Ll. 3-4). The beams and rafters were plated with gold (Text p. 1, L. 2) and the bottom of the roofs were covered with the feathers of kingfishers and peacocks. The upper part used to be decorated with artistic designs of mica, inlaid with leaves of gold, from which shone forth jewels and pearls, elegantly studded therein. Merchants, who went to trade overseas, had sometimes a fleet of a thousand ships. We need not place much reliance upon this description of the rustic poet. But the humble figure of fourteen ships,

generally mentioned in such accounts, seems to be a more rational number which we may believe.

With much margin left for the excesses of popular fancy, one cannot but be struck with an impression of the great wealth and grandeur of the Bengali merchants of those days, while perusing these ballads. A rich merchant's daughter always enjoyed the status of a princess. She had usually twelve maiden-escorts to attend her, when she went to the bathing ghat (Text, page 145, L. 1). She carried soap-berries and other toilet-articles in golden bòxes (Text, page 145, L. 4). Food was generally served to the rich people in golden plates. The infatuated chief would buy the favour of his lady-love by giving her landed estates, yielding seven lakhs a year (Text, page 175, L. 71). The mast of big merchant-vessels were plated with gold and the ensigns in which there were rich golden embroidery works, shone high up in the sky, reflecting the dazzling rays of the sun.

When a merchant reached his native shore after a successful sea-voyage, the elderly ladies used to come to the river-ghats to welcome the ships with due rites. The details of these rites are to be found in the Gitikathās, published by Mr. D. R. Mitra Mazumdar and called the 'Thakurdadar-Jhuli' and referred to in my work "The Folk Literature of Bengal" (pp. 65-68).

Though not marked by much pastoral poetry—the characteristic of the ballads of this class,—there are situations in this song, which are quite dramatic. The interest of the reader never flags and is even raised to a high intensity by a rapid succession of events, especially towards the end. The freshness of river-breeze, the wild life in turbulent waters, with ships, tossed by dashing waves, and the constant alarm caused by the pirates

are everywhere in evidence, reminding the reader that the scene of the ballads is laid in the wild river-districts of Eastern Bengal,—a country of swamps, marshes and great water-courses, where the roarings of clouds above are sometimes responded to by the clappings of a thousand waves, deafening the ears and where, every now and then, Nature assumes an awe-inspiring aspect in her sky and vast watery expanses.

The last scene where Abu Raja meets with the allied fleet of four great adversaries on the limitless waters of Chou Gangā takes us by a sublime dramatic surprise and this would be a fit theme for a thrilling cinematographic show, if it could be properly reproduced.

This ballad, in its original form, must have been very old, for it seems to trample down all the canons of Brahminic social system. The ideas were no doubt anterior to the foundation of the modern social life in Bengal. Both Bheluā and Menakā are seventeen years old when they themselves chose their bridegrooms (Text, p. 144, L. 33). The daughters are given perfectly free scope in love matters and their conduct is not called in question, even when they intrigue with strangers before their marriage. Society hardly condemns them. A woman, who lives with her elected lord as his wife, is sought after by another lover, who offers to marry her (not merely to pay her attentions as a mistress), with the full consent of his father and other elderly relations (Text, page 177, Ll. 13-16). When, after all kinds of adventurous love-makings, the woman returns home, she is accepted in a generous spirit of forgiveness so that throughout the whole of the poem, there are events and incidents, which seem to be subversive of all law and order of our present-day social fabric. I cannot say if these represent the conditions of an alien society of the Burmese and

Tibetans in particular, imbibed by the Rāja-Vaṃshis and Kāmbojis, among whom the ballad was originally current,—or they show a state of things that existed in Hindu society itself prior to the priestly Renaissance. One, who is at all conversant with the modern Hindu society, I mean, the society which is about seven hundred years old, could not have possibly conceived the incidents of the plot and it is for this reason that Bheluā is now mostly sung by Mahomedans, and the Hindus, even of the depraved castes, have given it up. The Brahmin is hardly mentioned in the ballad ; even when the merchant is distributing money at a religious function, the poet refers to the poor people as recipients of such charities and curiously here also the Brahmin has no place. (Text, page 206, L. 103). For such purposes in our society, the Brahmin would stand as the foremost claimant.

The one redeeming feature of the tale is that though the accounts do not show any respect for social or priestly conventions, the rustic mind that gave shape to it was conscious of that superior law in the sphere of tender emotions, which makes a woman adhere to a single object by her life-long devotion, and though surrounded and tempted by many suitors, retains her constancy in all her trials and would never break her vow of honour and chastity. Though she cares not for marriage-laws, made by men, she has the heart of the chaste and the devoted ones, clinging steadfastly to the lord of her heart, elected by herself.

The rhyme is very irregular and rugged. The metre halts in many places. This also shows that the original poem was composed in a remote age,—may be, in the pre-Muhammadan period, though it has undergone many changes in its language and spirit, during the long ages that have intervened.

This ballad was once very popular and used to be sung, throughout the vast tract of country, from the Soorma Valley on the Assam-borders to the sea-shores of Chittagong. I saw a printed edition of a ballad, called "Bhelua" a long time ago, to which I referred in my 'Banga Bhāshā-O-Sāhitya' in the year 1897. I drew the attention of my readers to the intermixture of Hindu and Moslem spirit, which found place in that version, published by a Muhammadan of Chittagong. I need scarcely say that the present version is quite unlike that one. I have presently noticed the awkward distortions of the simple country-ballads at the hands of the enterprizing Hindu and Moslem publishers. They invariably recast the ballads, introducing into them not only erotic scenes and gross things, but by thoroughly changing the style and making it approach more or less a classical model—not at all dignified, as the recensionists are not scholars at all but assume a false air of pedantry, which is very repellant. This takes away from the published editions the flavour of country life and the simple charm of rustic songs. The ballads in their hands look like the very tombs of the poetical ideas, with which the simple rustic had built his temple.

The Tale of Bhelua, the Beautiful One.

Canto I.

(1)

On the banks of the river Ujāni, there lived a merchant, named Murāi, in the village of Sankhapur. Hear, my learned audience, the tale of this merchant.

This merchant of Sankhapur was the lord of several towns. His wealth was immense. He worshipped Saturn, the planet, and by the grace of his deity, became the very prince of merchants. In fact, in the surrounding locality, there was none, who was his equal. So immense was his wealth that he measured his gold, like rice, in large scales. The story of his riches became proverbial in the countryside. His big houses had four, sometimes eight, slanting roofs. These were plated with gold, at the top. The beams were made of silver and the roofs were covered with gold-leaves, in place of straw. The rafters were ornamented with jewels and stones. His fleet consisted of a thousand merchant-vessels and it was a wonderful sight to behold the array of his ships, as they marched over the high seas, bound for trade. Their prows were plated with gold, the helms and the oars were of solid gold and the masts of gold raised their heads high up in the sky and the golden flags fluttered in the air, making a gorgeous show. In the landing-ghat of the river, adjoining the merchant's city, these ships lay anchored, awaiting his command.

Marching with the help of ebb-tide, and at times, struggling against the current, the merchant once arrived at a stream, near the Jaintā-Hills. I will tell you what the object of his travel was.

Murāi had, by the grace of Saturn, got a son, bright as the moon. The lad was twenty years old and shone with the lustre of gold or the morning-sun. He was called Madan, after the name of the god of Love. When the lad had passed his twentieth year, his parents became anxious to get a suitable bride for him.

Murāi was touring in different countries, not for trade, but in quest of a handsome and accomplished bride for his son.

I am going to leave the topic of Murāi here and make a little digression. My audience should now be ready to hear the story of Bheluā,—of her birth and other incidents of her life, of her beauty and accomplishments. (Ll. 1-43.)

(2)

I am going to relate to you the story of Bheluā. It is a wonderful story, divided into five parts. I crave the patient attention of my audience.

In the city of Kānchannagore there was a merchant named Manik, who, also, possessed immense wealth. His palace was divided into five large apartments, in which the audience-hall particularly, bore profuse decorations of gold. This hall had fifty-two doors; its roofs were covered with mica, adorned with jewels and pearls. The whole palace sparkled like the beams of the moon on the ripples of a river. Whoever beheld it admired the merchant's æsthetic taste. There were many large tanks inside the palace, with their landing-steps of solid silver. Inside one of these, was a temple, dedicated to

Lakshmi, the goddess of Fortune. Manik was descended from the illustrious merchant Chānd and had the status of a 'Kulin' in his community. Proud of his pedigree, the merchant held others in contempt. He had a daughter, handsome as Rati, the consort of Kāma, the god of Love. The beauty of Bheluā was a marvel. It shone like a flame, and there was nothing to be compared to it, in the whole world. Her hair was thick and black as cloud and her eyes were bright as stars. Youth had just dawned on her. Her slender figure had the brightness of gold and her eye-brows had the graceful curve of the rainbow. Her gait was so lovely that she seemed to spread a charm around her, as she walked. Her face was lovelier far than the moon. When she walked, her hair seemed to touch her feet; the maids held it up behind her back. When her curling hair fell over her lovely face, it seemed as if cloud covered the moon, for the time. Her father had given her jewels and ornaments, which, as it were, vied with one another in adorning her fair limbs.

The parents had given her the pet name of Bheluā, the beautiful. She had passed her sixteenth year and stepped into the seventeenth. The merchant was anxious for securing a bridegroom for her. He went about visiting different countries for trade and sought for a suitable groom everywhere. The suitors were not after his liking. He at first seemed to choose some one, but a little flaw was discovered, later on. In some cases the social status was not equal, so he could not agree to lower his prestige. "She is lovely as the moon," he reflected, "the man who will be given her hands must be bright as the sun." Day and night he had no other thought than that of the marriage of the daughter.

Then he settled a plan. He sent his five sons to fiv different countries to seek a bridegroom for Bheluā. He himself marched on board a ship and visited different countries with the same object in view.

"What will the success of my trade avail me and what good will my palace and wealth bring, if my daughter is kept unmarried?" Thus did he think day and night. (Ll. 1-46.)

(3)

Bheluā goes to the bathing-ghat and meets Madan, the young merchant.

She held in her hand a golden plate, containing soap-berry fruits, and also a silver one, containing betel, and proceeded towards the bathing-ghat, beaming like a flame of fire. The wives of the five brothers followed her, the twelve maids of Bheluā following in the train. The winds sported with her scented hair and the sweet smell of her perfumed body attracted the bees more than a flower-garden in the spring-season. Thus did Bheluā, the beautiful one, arrive at the landing steps of the river.

Now listen to what took place next, as recorded for her in the unalterable Book of Fate.

Young Madan just at the time, with fourteen ships, was going by the river, near Kānchannagar. He saw the beautiful town on the bank of the river and, being attracted by it, ordered his ships to be anchored there. There, on the landing-ghat, was Bheluā, with her maids, for a bath. The five sisters-in-law and Bheluā all came down and were in the mid-stream in an instant; they pleasantly laughed aloud and sported in the river. The five wives all swam till they came up to a great way in the stream, but Bheluā stopped and stood near the bank

and cast her curious eyes towards the approaching ships. She was attracted by the sight of the ships. "Who is this merchant? Whence has he come to our city? Which country will he visit for trade and where did he spend the last night?" Thoughts like this occurred to her. Her sisters-in-law saw that she was in a serious mood. For she did not swim with them, nor smiled and laughed, as usual. She hid her feelings from them and they wondered as to what produced this change in her mind. "A stranger he is certainly," she thought, as she adjusted her clothes to hide her charms. She was in knee-deep water and came further down and opened the braids of her hair, which floated on the water like clouds in the sky, and hid her moon-like face. At this moment, the young merchant came out of his cabin. "Is the morning-sun himself the captain of the ships?" She asked herself as she glanced at the young merchant, "or is it the moon that has fallen in the waves?"

Thus they saw each other for the first time in the river and the merchant's son at once felt the charm of her beauty. Both fell in love at first sight. It was like a meeting between the Sun and the Moon. What they had to tell one another was communicated by their eyes. She could not walk, so depressed she was; her feet, it seemed, refused to carry her back home. When she came up to the bank, she cast her glance on all sides to see if others had marked the change in her mind. Alas, her feet advanced slowly, but her mind wished to stay. Again they cast their eyes on one another and spoke everything by those silent messages which heart sends to heart. The message was understood by them and by none other. On board the ship, the youth peeped this way and that, his eyes seemed to say to her, "I am conquered." They bade adieu to one another by means

of their stolen glances. With the full weight of her long flowing hair, now wet, she seemed to walk heavily. The maids came to her rescue and held her tresses up. Then did she adjust her clothes once again and with slow steps, returned home.

Now what did the beautiful merchant do? He let his trained bird, the 'Suka' go in the air. The bird followed the girl and entered her compartment.

(Ll. 1-62.)

(4)

"Whence have you come, Oh bird, where is your house? By what name did the merchant use to call you? From what country has the merchant come and whither would he go? Oh the moment, when our eyes met first in the bathing-ghat! How handsome is he, like the moon! What dear name has been given him by his parents? He is surely going for trade, but on the way, he has acted like a thief and stolen my mind! He has taken my mind, my life and all that my youth yearns for. But wicked is he, not to have taken *me* with him! He smiles often, but his mind is not frank; with a glance, cast carelessly, he has caused me all this pain. I find no peace of mind at my home; it seems, my youth is struggling against the tide. If you know it, dear bird, tell me, like an informer, when will the dear merchant be coming back to our country, after he will have left it now?"

"On the banks of the river Ujāni is a village, named Sankhapur. There lives a merchant, named Murari. The youth is his son and his name is Madan. He has given me the name of Hiraman. The young merchant is going to foreign lands for trade. Wait, maiden, he will return and meet you again, at the bathing-ghat."

Madan had taught the bird this message and nothing more could the poor forest-bird, devoid of sense, say.

In slow whispers did the maiden again ask the bird question after question. But the bird made the same answer over and over again. For, beyond this, his master had not taught him anything.

The nights were bitter as poison. The charm of youth lost its lustre, owing to unhappy thoughts. She felt no rest either in pacing the courtyard or in lying in her bed. All the time, she felt an emptiness in her heart, which nothing could fill up. She brought a mate for the bird and looked at the pair, wishing ardently that she might meet the merchant in the same way.

Alas, to what country has he gone! Night and day she looks at the river and pursues with her eyes the course by which he would return. One day passed and she recorded it. Then the second, and then the third. In this way, unnumbered days came and went. She could not give up her hopes but lay expectant of his return all these long long days.

She took no care of her apparels, nor braided her flowing hair. Indifferent to everything, she looked like a girl, insane. The golden lustre of her form slowly faded away. What unnumbered tears did she not shed for the beloved merchant? The dark colour of her noble hair which had the look of summer-clouds, assumed a greyish tint without oil. She never combed it. Uncared-for, it grew matted. It was the freshliest period of youth. Yet she looked like a stern ascetic. People began to whisper as to what had become of her. She shut the doors of her bed-room and lying in her bed, on which smiled a hundred flowers, she smiled not, but spent her night in deep mental agony. Her floral couch became to her a bed of thorns.

She leaves the couches, and spreading a part of her *sadi*, lies down on the bare floor. There she sleeps and dreams that her young merchant has returned. Often does she awake with a start.

There she approaches the bird of her lover and says, " Go, dear friend, where the merchant has gone and tell him how I suffer." She asks the bird a hundred questions, alas, all in vain !

The attending maids whisper among themselves, " Alas, her head has gone wrong." (Ll. 1-60.)

(5)

Now listen, oh my audience, to what transpired on a particular day.

The young merchant returned from his voyage in the sea. There behold the red flag over a mast, glittering with golden embroidery. " A great merchant is coming this way," people say amongst themselves ; and the report comes to all. The bank of the river receives the dash of the waves, stirred by the ship, and the villagers assemble on the bank to have a sight of the merchant.

The report is heard by Bheluā. She thinks within herself, " What should I do now ? If my own merchant has come to this city in quest of me, how can I go to the bathing-ghat ? Who will accompany me ? Where shall I go,—to what country, with my beloved, if he will agree to take me with him ? " She indulges in all kinds of wild thoughts, like one who sleeps and dreams. Then she resumes her thought and goes on with her reveries. ' Many are the merchants who come and go by the river adjoining our city. Many have come and gone, but my sorrows have not come to an end. Who knows that this ship belongs to my beloved ? My hopes and wishes are like day-dreams ? Who will tell me that they will be

fulfilled and assure me that it is *he*, that is coming ? Alas, this ship may belong to some one else ! " At this thought her moon-like face became pale. The girl clasped the bird *Suka* with her arms and weepingly asked it question after question, " Tell me, O *Suka*, has your master come back in this ship ? "

Alas, the ignorant, the senseless bird repeated what it had said on the first day ; it gave an account of the merchant's parentage and home,—the only thing it had been trained to say.

* * * *

The great merchant Manik sat in his court, surrounded by his friends and officers. There our young hero, Madan, approached him with a present of some precious stones. The merchant said to the youth, " Who may you be, my young friend, possessed of such handsome features, shining as the moon ? What is the mission of your visit to this city of ours ? To what illustrious family do your father and mother belong ? Give me a full account of yourself."

Madan.

" My father is called Murari. He is a merchant. Our home is at a place called the Sankhapur on the Ujāni. I wander about in foreign lands for trade. My parents have given me the name of Madan. I am in some trouble and have come to you for help. I have made the sea my home, as most part of my life I spend in sea. The sea has swallowed my fourteen ships, with all my treasure. But most bitterly mourned has been the loss of my bird *Suka*, which I held dear, even as my life itself. During the hours of night, it flew away from me and I have become like one mad to miss it. I sent

people far and near in search of the bird, and only the other day the informer has given me the news that a bird, of the *Suka* species, has come over to your palace and that your daughter, Bheluā has taken a fancy for it and kept it concealed in her apartments."

Manik, the merchant, immediately sent a servant to the inner apartments, ordering that if such a bird actually was with his fair daughter she should at once give it up. The young merchant was right glad at this order. The servant brought the bird in a cage ; but before delivering it to Madan, the master of the city asked him to give proof that the bird belonged to him. Madan said, "I need not do that. The bird itself will do it." The trained bird sang that one song, which it had learnt to sing, namely, "There is a city named Sankhapur on the river Ujāni. There lives a merchant, named Murari. He has an only son and he is called Madan. He has given me the name Hiraman."

Manik, the merchant, was astonished at the account thus given by the bird, and made it over to young Madan with the cage. In return for the presents received, he bestowed jewels and precious stones on Madan as a mark of his favour. He came to his ship with the bird, and after having travelled a bend of the river, ordered the ship to be brought back to the station from which it had started. It was now night and he anchored his ship near the landing-ghat. Then he trained his Suka to recite the following words:

"Arise, O beautiful one, how long will you sleep ? It is I, Suka, who wants to speak to you. Behold, a thief has entered your garden of flower-plants. He has robbed it of all its treasure. Awake, arise, and see the night has advanced."

After having trained the bird in this way, he set it free at midnight to fly towards Bheluā's apartments.

The bird flew away, and reaching the palace of Bheluā, repeated what it had learnt in the evening.

The maiden rose up with a start, for she had hardly any sound sleep for many months. She opened the door and came out of her room.

In the sky, a star met her eyes,—floating in the blue. In the mid-firmament shone the moon and it was just past midnight. She sat a while, resting her head on her hands, and meditated as to how she could get free from her environment.

She did not raise her maids from sleep nor spoke to anyone else, but entered the flower-garden, all alone. She held in her hand the female-bird *Sāri* and lo, in an instant, her mate, the *Suka*, flew to her side. She caught hold of a branch of a flower-tree, that stood near by, and bent it low in order to pluck flowers. Now, what is it that she sees at a short distance? Has the moon come down from the sky to her flower-garden? They met in the depth of night and they retired to a lonely place and sat near one another.

Bheluā.

"Whence have you come here? Who showed you the way? Don't you know, dear, how miserable I have been for you? I have become mad. Is it a fair act on your part, a respectable merchant as you are, to come to one's flower-garden without permission and steal its flower?"

Madan.

"From the day I have seen you, fair maiden, I have become maddened by your beauty. No longer do I care for trade. My mind dreams of the fairy I saw first near the landing-ghat and thinks of nothing else."

He took out the diamond-ring, which adorned his finger and put it on the finger of the maiden. She, on her part, took away the garland of Mālati-flowers from her neck and hung it on the breast of her own Madan.

He said in murmurs, "Now, my sweetheart, farewell. The moon is on the wane. Let me depart hence and go home, before any one rises up and knows of my adventure."

"But how can I live, dear, without you? Come to my apartment and there I will cover you with my long flowing tresses. I will wander with you to lands, far and near. Upon my life, I tell you, I will leave my parents, my five brothers and this palace, in order to accompany you wherever you will lead me to. I cannot bear the idea of separation from you, now having tasted this sweet union. I fear, I may turn mad, if you leave me in this condition. Take me to your ship and with you I will go. But don't, for the sake of my life, leave me here to pine away alone! I will surely chew the diamond-ring [1] and die, if you desert me cruelly." Madan caressed her endearingly and said, "I am planning how to marry you. I must first go to my father and tell him everything. Meantime, have patience, my darling, I promise, you will not have many days to wait."

"If indeed you are to leave me, kindly make me a gift of your bird, Suka." He smiled and said good humouredly, "My bird is worth a lakh of rupees. What price are you going to offer for it, my dear?" She said, "Yes, I shall give its price. I have a female-bird of the species; it is my *Sāri*. Let us make an exchange." "That is not enough," said the merchant, "what else

[1] There is a tradition in this country that the diamond is poisonous and that many people have committed suicide by chewing their rings.

will you give me?" "That I have already given. That is my own self," murmured the beautiful one.

So he bade her farewell. The night was nearly over. The humming of the bees was heard in the garden. He came back to his ship and started homewards. It usually takes one six months to reach Sankhanagar from that place. But the young merchant hurried on and his native shores were reached in one month. The ladies of his palace, as soon as the report of his return was received, came to the banks of the river and after usual rites, carried home what treasure he had got by trade. The captain helped in unloading the ships. The women welcomed him with cries of "Victory" and the father asked his son many questions regarding his voyage abroad. (Ll. 1-150.)

(6)

But the thought of Bheluā was now uppermost in his mind. He looked pale like morning, covered by a thin cloud. It was an ailment, which made him sick at heart—a disease, which no doctor could correctly diagnose. The parents did not understand what their dear son suffered from. His friends talked among themselves and tried to find out the cause of his depression in spirits, but could not hit at the reason. But such a thing could not be long suppressed. Unable to keep his feelings secret, he divulged it to a comrade. A second one also came to know of it, so that, after a time, many of his friends knew the whole thing, and last of all the father himself heard of it one day from one of the intimate friends of Madan.

As soon as Murari, the merchant-prince, learnt of the desire of his son, he ordered fourteen ships to be prepared. They were laden with various goods. A match-maker

was called in. Together with the goods, the merchant sent a few diamonds and precious stones, to be presented to the merchant, Manik, of Kanchannagar. He sent the match-maker in order to propose the marriage.

The match-maker arrived at Kanchannagar and duly communicated the message to Manik, the merchant-prince of Kanchannagar, in the following words:

"We have learnt that you have a daughter of surpassing beauty. I have come to propose a match for her. On the banks of the river Ujani, there is a town, named Sankhapur. This town belongs to the merchant-prince, Murari. His only son is Madan. The old merchant has sent me here for proposing his son's marriage with your fair daughter. Young Madan is handsome as the god Kartikeya. His accomplishments and handsome appearance make him truly worthy of your daughter's hands."

For a moment Manik sat still, meditating within himself, and then addressed the match-maker and said before his court :—

"I must tell you something about my lineage. My great ancestor was Chand, the merchant of world-wide repute, whose son Likshindara was killed by snake-bite. I enjoy the highest social honour in my community. If I offer my daughter to one of inferior status, I shall be humbled in the eyes of my community. When any social function takes place, the merchants assembled do me a distinct honour by offering me food on a golden plate; a special seat is reserved for me there. In point of honour, social status and wealth, my family occupies the highest position and my community admits it in every social function. How can I lower myself by offering the hands of my daughter to one, who has not acquired the status of a Kulin. If it were my son, the

case would have been different. A daughter, you know well, cannot be given away to a family, less respectable than mine. My family shines bright like the moon. It will be spotted with dishonour, should I accede to your proposal. Many are the proposals that I have hitherto received. But I cannot entertain them for this reason."

The Ghatak took his leave, and returning to Shankhapur, related the whole story to Murari in private. He became sorry, when he heard it and felt greatly humiliated by the arrogance of Manik, the merchant.

But when young Madan heard of it, it seemed his heart was pierced by a spear or as if a thunderbolt fell on his head. Home became like a hell to him and he took leave of his parents, saying that he would go abroad for trade. The astrologer fixed an auspicious date and with fourteen ships, he started on sea-voyage with various commodities.

He took the bird *Sāri*, the present of his beloved in his hand; and bade adieu to his parents requesting them to allow the maid Saluka to accompany him. On the day fixed, he started for distant countries with Saluka, the maid, as his companion and confidante. The ships went through the high seas and at last Kanchannagar was in sight. When there were yet a few bends to cross, the ship marching by the flow-tide, the young man told the maid Saluka all about the pain of his heart. He concluded by saying, " Jewels and precious stones I will present to you to your heart's content. Now you must save my life at this crisis. Take this *Sāri* with you and go about the town on the pretext of selling it there. She who will set no price to it but demand it as a matter of right, to be sure, that one you must know to be Bheluā, the beautiful one. Have a private conversation with her and give her the *Sāri*, which, in reality, belongs to her and which she loves dearly. Tell her, if there be really no chance of my

being united with her, I swear by this ebb-tide, I will fling myself into the river and drown myself. Tell her privately that if she has any love for me, let her meet me in the flower-garden."

She took the cage in hand, containing the bird and paid a visit to the town. She went to the palace of the merchant-prince and sought a purchaser for the bird. But none came forward to buy it. She then entered the apartments of Bheluā. She was lying on a rich couch, her profuse hair lay dishevelled on all sides. Saluka stopped there and laid down the cage. Bheluā instantly recognised her own bird and asked in a tone of entreaty, "Tell me, maiden, where you got this bird."

"My profession," said Saluka, "is to sell birds. I wander, in quest of purchasers, from town to town. Now I will tell you the story of this *Sāri*. This Sāri and her mate lived in a great forest, where there were big fig trees. These were blown down by a storm all on a sudden and the bird Suka flew away to a distant country, leaving his consort forlorn and in great distress. This little thing flew on and on and at last, all tired, allowed herself to be caught by me and I have since put it in this cage and have been trying to get a purchaser." "I will reward you," said Bheluā, "with precious stones and jewels, if you can give tidings about him. For I am sure, you know all the facts. Tell me, without reserve, if you have pity for my life." Saying so, she took the golden necklace from her breast and presented it to Saluka.

"What is the price you want for the *Sāri*," she said again, "Tell me the truth and do not deceive me."

Saluka said, "Listen to me, O beautiful one, one who will set no price to it but demand it as a matter of right, to her may I give it,—to none else."

She gently drew Bheluā with her soft hands to the shade of a tree. It was a lonely place and there did she sweetly murmur to her ears. "At a distance of fourteen bends from this city, where the ebb-tide flows, your lover waits with fourteen ships. Hear what tidings he has sent for you. If you have any love for him, meet him in the flower-garden, adjoining your compartment."

With these words, Saluka took leave of her and went to where the merchant was waiting when there was an ebb-tide in the river at the distance of fourteen bends from the city.

* * * * *

Her day does not come to an end, so cruelly tedious seems the march of time; nor does the night come. There was no pleasure in taking the meals, nor does she comb her hair.

The evening at last came to an end and the night presented itself to the palace of the old merchant. She lay on a couch in her room and thought random thoughts, all alone.

Then as the night advanced, she began to comb her hair and bind it into a chignon. She wove a garland of Mālati-flowers and hung it on her neck. She took a betel, the purple hue of which adorned her sweet lips. It seemed as if the ebb-tide had passed, giving place to flow-tide; she seemed to revive with the fullness of youth, her handsome face became doubly so. When it was about 10 o'clock, her toilet and dressing were finished. The next three hours she spent, sometimes awake, sometimes sleeping, till it was the last part of the night, when she left her bed and came to the flower-garden. There in the garden, touched by the gentle air of the latter part of the night, Mallikā, Mālati, Gandharāj,

Tagar, and Jessamine bloomed in splendid array, making the spot one of the loveliest in the palace. She plucked the flowers, and seated in a lovely place, wove a beautiful garland with them.

There the rustling of leaves was heard. She spread her *Sāri* and slept. But suddenly opening her eyes, she saw some one, sleeping in the shade of a tree. She slowly approached and at once recognised him. She called him aloud, "How long will you sleep, my beloved! awake and see, before you, your own wretched Bheluā. Just look towards the East. Does not the sky there show the glamour of the rising sun? If night comes to an end, danger may befall us."

He heard her voice as if in a dream and then opened his eyes, from which the illusion of a dream had not yet passed away. He embraced her and said sweetly, "What is it fair maiden, that you have resolved to do? For me, I assure you, I have given up all hopes. If I cannot get you, I will throw myself into the river and die. My fourteen ships will I sink thither, so that there may be no trace left of me. Now be quick, we have no time to lose. If you will make up your mind to leave your parents and go with me, there is not a single moment to lose. The night is nearly over, no time for vain talk. If you agree, come with me, and I will immediately start with you, with my fourteen ships, for my native land."

Bheluā.

"O Sun, that is rising and O Moon, that is setting, be my witness. O creepers and trees of the forest, be my witness. I leave my father and mother and five brothers to-day. I leave my dear native city of Kānchannagar. I leave my companions, my dear maidens all. I am

desperately in love. For his sake I go to a distant country. Now adieu to you, O ye birds, that wander in the sky, and the plants and trees that abound in this city. Hide from my mother the tale of my scandal. If she asks you all as to where I have gone, tell her, "Your Bheluā, dear as your life, has been drowned in yonder river." I have not sought permission from my father or brothers. I have put the shame of scandal on their brows for ever. For the sake of my love, I have become like one, that has gone mad. O my friends of Kānchannagar, I bid you farewell in this solitude, in this depth of the night. I leave you all, all who were dear to me up to now, for the sake of one, who is now the dearest."

With fourteen ships and with Bheluā as the richest treasure of them, did the young merchant return to Sankhapur. The voice of welcome was heard in the town. First of all came the mother, and then the aunts of Madan, to give him reception with their blessings of *Dhān* and *Durbā* (rice and grass). Now, all on a sudden, a rumour spread in the country that the young merchant had brought in his ship a wonderfully beautiful woman. "He must have stolen her," whispered the citizens, "from some unknown place. Her hair in its curly and wavy dance almost touches her feet. There is no maiden as beautiful as this girl in our city." When the report reached the old merchant Murari, he called Madan to his presence and asked him what truth was there in the public rumour. "What has been your profit by the last voyage and where did you get the beautiful girl?"

Madan hid nothing from his father but made a clean breast of the whole affair and related the story of his love in full.

Murari was wroth. He knit his brows and said in a harsh tone, "Get out of my city. I had sent a

match-maker with the proposal, but he returned insulted. And you have, like a thief, stolen that maiden and brought her to my house. This will blacken the fair name of my family in the eyes of people for ever. Better I had no son than a son like you. You have destroyed the honour of an honoured house. I am resolved that I shall have nothing to do with you in future. I would have called an executioner and had your head cut off, but that would be going too far. Go, and return the maiden to her parents and never venture to come back to Sankhapur."

The mother cried and the sisters cried. There was a shadow of great grief all over the city. Madan came to a ship with Bheluā and went by the sea for some days till he reached Ranchapur, the city of Raja Abu.

Raja Abu was a pirate,—a disgrace and shame to his noble family. With what wealth and goods he had, Madan approached the Raja, seeking shelter. Abu was pleased with the precious stones that the young merchant presented him and gave him a good house to live in.

Here lived Madan with Bheluā for some time. I am now going to relate to you what followed.

Oh my audience, I have now finished two parts of the poem, I shall relate to you the incidents of the third part. (Ll. 1-202.)

PART III.

(7)

I will now speak, in detail, about Raja Abu of Ranchapur. His wealth and power were unlimited. He was a demon incarnate and every one held him in awe. The tiger and buffalo drank from the same fountain without quarelling with each other,—such was the dread in which he was held in his dominion. He had as many as five hundred beautiful wives in his harem. But unsatisfied still, he was always on the lookout for fair damsels of respectable houses. The spies were ever ready, giving him information about handsome women, and as soon as he got the report, he carried them by force to his palace. He was an enemy to the people and cared not at all for the gods. Women and wealth he plundered from everywhere. It was at the city of such a vicious chief that Madan built a house and lived for some time. Now hear what followed next.

There was a barber-woman named Kausalyā, who went to the house of our young merchant one day to help Bheluā in her toilet. She was struck with the splendid-looking house with its rich furniture and decorations, which bore ample signs of wealth in every room. But the most valuable of all the wealth of the house was the fair-looking Bheluā herself. The barber-woman admired her beauty and thought that she had never before seen a woman, handsome as that one. She looked glorious in her youth like the moon with a halo round her. The barber-woman came home

and told her husband that the young merchant possessed a diamond which was worth all the riches of seven kings. "Her beauty is wonderful," she said, "her face is like the moon. I saw her lying on her couch with hair dishevelled. Youth has just dawned on her and the profuse curly hair, I saw, touched her feet playfully. I never saw any woman, whose hair is so wonderfully long. The hue of gold emanates from her body and her eyes are soft and sparkling as stars. If you happen to go to the palace of Raja Abu, give him this piece of information. I am sure, as soon as he will get this report, gladly will he reward you with gold in profusion."

The barber.—"It is a clever bait that you have laid before me, my good wife. There is a little danger, however, in the matter. If our story proves untrue, he will have me beheaded forthwith. You say that her hair is very long and that you never saw any hair of the human head with such a curling grace. Now I will give the information to the Raja, if you will secure for me a hair from her head, so that I may show it to His Majesty."

Now, on some pretext or other, the barber-woman again paid a visit to the house of our young merchant. She saw Bheluā, lying on her couch and looking handsome as Rati, wife of the god of Love. She openly praised her beauty, which surpassed that of all other women. She gently touched her body and pressed her beautiful feet with her hands and said, "Even the nails of your toes have the lustre of the moon. Rarely fine must have been the stuff with which the Creator made this angelic form of yours. I never saw the hair of human head so luxuriantly long and curling. The moon seems to be stricken by shame at the sight of your beauty. The hue of gold is seen in your body and your eyes are soft and sparkling like stars. Really, I never saw a woman,

so beautiful. There are five hundred fair women in the harem of Raja Abu and none of them is worthy even of being your maid-servant. Your husband, fair lady, is one of the most handsome youg men that I have ever seen, and you are fully worthy of him."

She gently touched the fair maiden, pressing her hands and feet softly and fanned her at times with a fan, decorated with mica, while she went on saying "Had you been the consort of an Emperor, he would have adorned your body with diamonds; he would have been your very slave, carrying out your least wishes with the obedience of a menial." She continued babbling in this way and Bheluā, under the cooling influence of the fan, closed her eyes in sleep. And now the barber-woman watched her for a moment, and with the help of a grain of rice, gently plucked one of the hairs from her head, and thus gaining her object, tied the hair in the edge of her *Sāri* and went straightway to her home. She presented the hair to her husband. The beauty and length of that single hair filled the mind of the barber with astonishment and he exclaimed, "In my early days, I heard a fairy tale. The dream of my childhood is fulfilled to-day. Whence has the young merchant obtained this fairy?"

The barber went to the palace, as usual, and with a razor in hand, was about to ply his task. But the king said, "I cannot spare time to-day for shaving. You have come without notice."

The barber.—"Really it is not for shaving that I am here to-day. I have dreamt a dream, which I would like to communicate to Your Majesty."

"What is it?" asked the Raja.

The barber.—"It is a private matter. Not here."

They went to a private chamber, where the barber spoke to him all about the beauty of the

merchant's wife and then he handed over the long hair.

The Raja felt a thrill in his heart, as he touched the soft thing of wondrous length and then discussed with the barber as to how he could secure Bheluā. He sent for Madan, and when the latter appeared in his presence, he said, "You are aware, my young friend, that I have five hundred queens in my harem. But woe to me, not one of them is fit to be the chief Queen! I want a lady whose colour will be like that of a golden beetle. Go forth in search of such a lady. A friend of mine, a merchant living in a distant country, has given me information about such a lady and has sent me a hair from her head. It is here. Take it with you and find the girl out. You must report to me of any girl whose hair is as glossy and long as this one. Be satisfied that the lady has the colour of a true gold beetle and hair of the length of this one (he hands over the hair to the merchant). If you can get for me such a lady, I will make her my chief Queen. If, through your kind help, I can have such a one for my harem, I will reward you with a palatial house, which will glitter with its gold-decorations and you will, besides, have the gift of twenty *purahs* of rent-free land from me. I will also find an exceedingly beautiful girl and get her married to you."

Sad at heart, with the hair in his hand, did the young merchant return home that day. (Ll. 1-110.)

Madan.

"O Bheluā, dear as life, hear the sad tale. A thunder-bolt will shortly fall on my head. We were enjoying the flow-tide of fortune all this time, but the ebb-tide has set

in from to-day. Our fourteen noble ships will sink down in the sea to-day. The full moon will be covered with clouds and fire will break out in this house of pleasure, that we have built here. We came floating like stars in the stream of distress and hoped to find refuge in this land of a demon. Here we are destined to meet a miserable end. From my own dear native land, I have been banished for your sake. But I bore this banishment with a gladsome heart since you are by far more valuable to me than anything else. Your beauty is now a source of eternal trouble to you and your youth is your enemy to-day. Now, my sweetheart, cut off your long flowing hair and besmear your golden colour with soot. The wicked king has ordered that I shall go to distant lands, leaving you here."

When she heard this, Bheluā felt as if a thunderbolt had fallen on her head; the hair of her body stood at their ends in fright.

They both set their wits together, planning means of escape. The merchant said, "In course of this day, I shall have to start from here. This is the order on me. It is for securing you, dear Bheluā, that the king sends me to distant lands. So if I take you with me, there will be no escape. A female spy has given him information about your beauty and he sends me away to make his way clear. Now listen to my plan. Near the Jaintia hills, there lives a merchant, named Hiran, a particular friend of mine. There you will have to go from here. I leave a boat in the river made of light "*man pavan*" wood; the oars thereof are made by the famous artisans of Maldah. This boat will be your only hope in this dangerous night. I will take the bird Suka, leaving the female Sāri with you. If, by the grace of Mother Durga, you may flee from this land with the help of this boat,

then go straightway to Jaiteswar, where my friend lives, and wait there for me. If you cannot effect your escape, I need not remind you of the diamond-ring on your finger, the refuge of all chaste women in their distress. If the situation be a desperate one chew it and die. For myself, if such a thing happens, I will drown myself in the sea with my fourteen ships and will never show my face to any mortal."

Early in the morning the merchant started with fourteen ships.

Abu Raja's generals and soldiers now proceeded to the merchant's house and surrounded it like ants. The Raja entered the inner apartments and there saw Bheluā, whose beauty at once charmed him. With the flowing tresses, long and glossy, with the colour that shone bright as that of the golden beetle, she stood in front of him, like the moon descended on the earth. The Raja said, "Come to my palace, dear lady, I will be a slave to your wishes. I have five hundred queens in my harem; they will all be your slaves." Bheluā said, "I pray for justice, O mighty monarch. I have a complaint to lodge before Your Majesty. Madan, the young merchant, played wickedly with me; he carried me away from my father's palace, while I was sleeping, all alone, in my garden-house. My sleep was to me the source of the great danger that followed. He carried me into the ship and came up here to escape the wrath of my parents and five brothers. I have been cut off from my kith and kin and am leading this deplorable life. No more shall I see my parents, nor my five brothers. No more shall I have the privilege of talking gaily with the wives of my brothers. People are spreading all sorts of scandals, and I am weary of life. I shall chew my diamond-ring and die of the poison." As she said so, she was about to act

up to her threat, when the Raja intervened and said, "What are you doing, fair girl? Do not rashly chew the diamond-ring. I will make you a gift of landed estates, yielding seven lakhs a year, and I shall, as I have said, be a slave to your wishes. Near the temple of Kāli, in my palace, I have made a new altar; there shall I sacrifice Madan as soon as he comes back. Come to my palace; there the couches and sofas have been softly spread for you. I will make you happy by all means. You will be the owner of immense wealth, of hoards of jewels and diamonds, and to crown your happiness, I will make you my chief Queen."

Bheluā.

"I have my parents and brothers at my home. How can I marry without their consent? My father lives at Kanchannagar, and he is known as Manik, the merchant. There send information at once. My parents and brothers will all come up here, and in the presence of them all, the marriage will take place. Wait these few days and do not pay a visit to my chambers. Stay at your palace these few days. If, however, you do not agree to my wishes, I will end my life by chewing this diamond-ring.

The Raja was right glad and sent a messenger to Kanchannagar. In the meantime, Bheluā began to discuss with Saluka as to how she could proceed to the city of Jaiteswar. Just as a wild bird, put in a cage, cuts with its beak the wooden rods, and tries to break the chain of its feet by constant biting, it was even so with Bheluā who constantly tried to effect her escape from the city of Abu Raja. Three days passed and on the fourth, Bheluā came to the river-ghat on the pretext of floating lights in the water,—a rite which Hindu

women perform in some special months of the year. She took with her the maid Saluka and also her dear bird *Sāri* and went into the boat of *man pavan*. They both plied the oars, made by Maldah carpenters. The night was dark and the waves roared menacingly, and over them floated the small boat of *man pavan*. The wind was trembling and the sail was backed by strong wind, and the boat crossed rivers with the speed of a shooting star. Even without knowing the way, they plied the oars in unknown regions, and the boat reached the shore in half a day, which, in usual course, would take three days to reach. The city of Rangchapur, the abode of Raja Abu, lay at a great distance and the boat of *man pavan* approached the city of Jayanta.

(Ll. 1-106.)

(9)

When they reached the city of Jaintā, Bheluā, with her maid Saluka, went to the palace of the merchant Hiran. She introduced herself as the wife of his friend Madan. But Hiran, as soon as he saw Bheluā, became enamoured of her. Strange that the flower itself came flying to the bee, so unexpected it was. What if the hedge, raised around the field to protect its corn, itself took to eating up its protegé, the corn ? It was a case like that,—all this being the result of evil destiny.

" How unfortunate am I," cried Bheluā. " Whenever I catch a branch for shelter, it breaks at my touch. Alas, my beauty has become my enemy and my youth the cause of my ruin."

A few days passed. The girl remained at Jaiteswar without finding any means of escape.

Meantime the merchant Hiran discussed with his people as to how he could win the hands of Bheluā and

marry her himself. At last he confided the secret of his heart to his old father. The old man thought over the question for a moment, but at last being swayed by an undue affection for his son, yielded and gave his consent to Hiran's marriage with his friend's wife.

The whole thing was so secretly arranged that Bheluā could have no inkling of it at the outset.

Now Hiran had a sister named Menakā. Youth had just dawned on her; she was a paragon of beauty. She was in fact considered to be the most valuable treasure of that family. The stars of heaven looked pale before her bright eyes, when she gazed upwards, and the moon was stricken with shame at the lustre of her face. She had just completed her sixteenth year and stepped into the seventeenth.

Some years ago, Madan had paid a visit to his friend Hiran's house and there they both saw one another. Menakā fell in love with him and began to brood over her feelings in solitude. Madan and she met privately and both seemed to exchange words of love.[1] There was a whisper in the city about the marriage of the pair. Meantime, Bheluā came there and the matter grew complicated. The proposal of Menakā's marriage with Madan could not be seriously entertained, as the time was declared to be inauspicious by astrologers.

From the first day of her arrival at the city of Jaiteswar, Bheluā and Menakā became fast friends. Menakā now learnt everything and felt that she would surely meet Madan soon. The snake had left the jewel of its head there, and it was sure to come in search of its treasure. Both confided to one another their love for Madan and felt a relief by unloading their sorrows to one

[1] This had been, of course, before Madan saw and loved Bheluā.

another.[1] They both became one soul, one mind. At dinner, in the sleeping bed and everywhere they kept inseparable company. They bathed from the same landing-ghat of the river; they slept together on the same bed. They ate from the same plate. In fact they became as one body and soul.

The day of marriage (of Hiran with Bheluā) approached, and drums were beaten in the city. The flute-players of Jaita merrily played on their pipes.

Menakā one day privately said to Bheluā, "My wicked brother, O sister, is enamoured of your beauty and will marry you. My father, who, owing to his dotage and foolish affection for my brother, has lost his sense, has given his consent to such an unholy thing."

Bheluā felt stupefied by the dire news and could not speak for sometime. She then lamented her fate in this way, "I came to a friend's house in great distress, just as a traveller comes to the shade of a tree for protection from the sun. Alas! the powerful sun sends its burning rays through the leaves and allows him no relief. I prepared a bed for taking rest and laid myself thereon. Alas, the house caught fire and burnt it, owing to my evil luck."[2]

Menakā.

"Do not lament, sister, call my brother to your presence and ask him to grant you three months' time before consenting to this marriage. If your husband still lives, he will not go to Rangchapur but come to our city. If within these three months he does not turn up, both of us will drown ourselves in a pond.

[1] As a man often took more than one wife in those days, there was generally no sting of jealousy in a woman's heart, when her husband married a second woman. She often took the matter lightly and even graciously.

[2] *Cf.* "সুখের লাগিয়ে, এঘর বাঁধিনু, অনলে পুড়িয়ে গেল"—Chandidas.

Bheluā took the advice and sought an interview with Hiran. She said to Hiran, "You want to marry me; that is all right. But you must give me three months' time for deciding my course. My husband has gone out for trade. I do not know if he is still alive or not. Marry me after three months. You must wait till this time and should not proceed further in your attempt to win me. If you do not agree to my request, I will chew the diamond-ring and put an end to my life."

Hiran very privately discussed the matter with his people and made up his mind to follow this project, namely, that he would start from home on the pretext of trade and find out his quondam friend Madan, now an enemy. If he can meet him on the way, he will assassinate him. He matured this plan, and before setting out, saw Bheluā and said, "It is for your sake, dear girl, that I am going to distant lands, in quest of my dear friend, your husband. If I can find him out, rest assured that I will bring him up here with me. I start after two days hence; I have come to take leave of you."

Honey was in his mouth but poison in his heart, when he told this to Bheluā and bade her farewell.

Menakā overheard all that passed between Hiran and his friends. She divulged the secret intentions of her brother to Bheluā. Bheluā became mad with grief at the report, but controlling herself as best as she could, taught her parrot, the *sāri*, her little tale of woe. Briefly she recited to the *sāri* the story as to how she came from Abu Raja's city to Jaiteswar, how Hiran consulted his friends and developed the plan of murdering him, and the sorrows she had been suffering so long. "You are to shun the company of your friend and fly away from him with the utmost speed. He goes to kill you. I am like a bird, put into the cage in this city. Do not think of

your unfortunate Bheluā any more. I will throw myself into fire and die, or cut my throat with a knife. If you still live, never come to this city of Jaiteswar. If you do, death will be sure. Alas! my beauty has become my bane and my youth the cause of my ruin."

When the *sāri* was trained, Bheluā sent for Hiran and insisted, in tender words, on his taking the bird with him. She said, "Go to distant lands with this *sāri* of mine. Take care that you do not lose this bird. Whatever country you may happen to visit, you should bring from it some new thing, some curiosity, after my choice, as a present for me. This *sāri* knows well the things I like and it will let you know by signs what I would prize. You are to purchase those things and bring them for me in your ship."

Right glad was Hiran at this request from the fair one and considered himself as a crowned king, being favoured with this command from the lady.

He took the bird with him and set out for distant lands.

Following the ebb-tide, he proceeded, and after seven days met Madan. He had laid anchor to his ship and was bathing in the river, where Hiran met him with the bird in his hand. They embraced each other, having met after such a long time. All the time Hiran was bent upon devising some place to kill his friend. At this stage, the bird *sāri* was seen by Madan, who at once recognised it. He naturally took a great interest in the pet bird of his wife and enquired of his friend as to where he could have got it. He caught it and kept it near him with his friend's permission.

At the still hour of night Madan brought the bird near him and said, "You must have been sent here by Bheluā. Please recite to me the words that she might

have taught you at the time of parting." Then did the bird deliver its message in the following way, without understanding it: "She escaped from the city of Abu Raja by the help of the boat of *man pavan* and came to the palace of Hiran, the merchant. This young man got enamoured of her. He has planned to kill you." "Fly, my lord, fly in all haste to your own country. Do not tarry a moment to brood over my fate. Like a wild bird, put in the cage, I am here in this city. Do not think of your unfortunate Bheluā any more. I will throw myself into fire and die or cut my throat with a knife. If you are alive, my friend, do not come to this city of Jaiteswar. Here death will be sure. Alas, my beauty has become my bane and my youth the cause of my ruin."

Big drops fell from Madan's eyes, as he thought over the condition of his beloved wife. Two-thirds of the night passed and only one-third remained. Hiran, the merchant, was enjoying deep sleep in his ship. He would put poison in a betel and with that kill Madan the next day. This he had planned. Madan, who had not slept at all, rose from his bed at the dead of night. He cut the chain of his ship, which was moored there, and set sail to it. Taking advantage of the ebb-tide and the favourable winds, the ship marched on, and in four days, the city of Jaiteswar came into sight. In usual course, it would take a month to reach the place. He laid anchor to the ship at a bend of the river and in the disguise of a hawker came to the city with the bird in his hand. He cried out for a purchaser of the bird, and travelling through the paths of the city, arrived at the house of Hiran Sadāgar. The report reached the inner apartments of his house and Bheluā at once recognised the bird. She offered a price in the shape of her finger-ring to the seller and purchased her own *sāri*.

"Oh my *sāri*, O my pet bird, dear as my life, tell me now where my husband is. You must have travelled a good deal. Tell me now what countries you saw. Have you met my dear husband and has he taught you any message for me?"

The *sāri* had learnt a song, which it began to sing.

"Yes, yes, dear lady, I have seen your dear husband. He wanders about in the guise of a hawker in quest of you. He has become mad for you. He spends his days without meals and nights without sleep. At the bend of the river, where flows the ebb-tide, he is waiting for you with his ship. Manage anyhow to escape from this palace and meet him there."

Bheluā now took leave of Menakā with tears in her eyes. They both wept at the hour of parting. In the dead hour of night, she left Hiran's house with the bird *sāri* in her hand. She reached the bend of the river, where the ship of the merchant lay anchored. Nobody knew of her flight except Menakā in that large city.

The merchant cut the ropes and set sail to the ship, which swiftly ran through the waters in the ebb-tide. After a short journey, the flow-tide set in and the ship went against the current, aided by the wind. Madan felt as if he had obtained the moon in his hands. He embraced his consort, and both were blinded by tears of joy, so that they could not see one another for some time. They had met at last, but were afraid lest they should again be separated by cruel destiny. The day passed and the night came. The night also passed and another day dawned. They saw, in their front, a shoal, known as *Kaichar bāk*. Who is it whom they see coming in that direction? From what country does he come, raising a flag over his ship? At the sight of this, Madan became pale with fear. There the merchant Manik, the father of

Bheluā, is coming with her five brothers. Madan recognised the ship and, turning to the contrary course, went in the direction of the current. But after going some distance, he saw another flag, in front of him, and again became pale with fear. It was the flag of Abu Raja's ship. He again turned to the contrary direction and took another course. With the speed of a shooting star did his ship steer on, but there was yet another ship, which nearly overtook him. It was the ship of Dhananjaya, the merchant, who was advancing with his fourteen ships, with a large number of men and amongst the crew was there the beautiful Menakā. Three bends of the river Madan crossed but in front he could recognise from the flag that the young merchant Hiran was approaching towards him. It was on the vast watery expanse of *Chougangā*, the confluence of four rivers, where Madan felt his position a critical one, surrounded as he was by enemies on all sides. There was no escape this time. Providence was against him.

Her hair was all dishevelled and her face was bright, this being the dawn of her youth. Bheluā ran like a mad woman through the deck of the ship and threw herself into the water. Slowly did the black hair of her head, like clouds strewn over the river, sink in it. Menakā, who observed her from another ship, also, threw herself into the river and caught hold of the hair of her head. They were both seen struggling in the river and at this point Madan, also, threw himself into the waters. "Oh my Bheluā, oh dearer than life, what is it that you have done?" were the words that he had uttered before he jumped into the river.

At this time the sky became menacingly black and underneath, the great river swelled, till the whole region seemed to be swallowed by waters. The sails of the ships

were rent by storm and the rivers roared, rising far above her banks. The ships all capsized. In the four directions, the ships of the four merchants all went straight into the bottom of the river with the crew. They passed through a death-struggle in the vast expense of *Chougangā*. None could help the others in that critical situation. Alas! who would help his comrades to step into the shore, helplessly scattered as they were. Where, alas, was Madan, the merchant? Where was Abu Raja? Hiran, the merchant, was, also, punished by Providence, as he deserved.

The ships capsized and were carried far away. Alas! where was the beautiful Bheluā gone, dearer to Madan far than his life? (Ll. 1-258.)

(10)

A grave-looking old merchant of saintly character was passing by the river against the current in that region. His ship was plated with gold and the flag bore the embroidery of mica. It was loaded with gold and precious stones. The flag was seen far above in the sky. The ship, as already stated, was going against the current. She suddenly stuck into the shoal. The sail was pulled down and the helmsman and those, who plied the oars, exhausted their strength in their attempt to make the ship free. But she would not move in the least and the merchant in that dangerous situation felt as if some one had struck him with an axe on the head,—so stupefied he was at this crisis. Four days passed in this way and now listen to me, oh brethren, what transpired next. The oarsmen were striding over that lovely shoal and they espied, at some distance, two figures, bright as the sun and the moon, lying with their swan-like necks on the sand. They looked more like dead than living. Alas,

what unfortunate man had lost his best treasures on these sandy banks?

The old merchant had dreamt a dream last night. Was that fair dream going to be fulfilled to-day? The oarsmen came to him and said, "Look here, Oh master, the sun and the moon are lying on yonder sandy bank." What did the merchant do at this report? He hied to the banks. He found the sun and the moon, dropped from the sky and lying on the sands. He brought them to his ship.

He gave them fine apparel and jewels to wear; they were, besides, served with rich meals. The ship went against the tide and in a few days, they reached the shore of the merchant's country. When the ships came to the landing-ghat, the women of the city accorded the merchant a hearty reception by singing songs of welcome. With rice and tufts of *Durva*-grass, the female members of the merchant's house came to the *ghat* in order to welcome the treasures brought. They first placed flowers and sandal-paste on the prow of the ships, and then invoked hymns in honour of Padmā (Manasā Devi) and bent their heads in obeisance to that deity. They carried the vessels, in which were stored up the treasures of the ships, one by one, and then suddenly they saw the two beautiful girls of exceeding beauty. The citizens assembled there and were astonished at the sight. They said, in low murmurs, "We never saw such women, nor ever heard of such exquisite beauty. Whence has our merchant brought them?" The wife of the merchant said, "What country did you travel during the voyage and from where have you secured this wonderful treasure? We have no children; our house is dark. From what golden city have you brought these darlings? I take them as gifts from God; lucky is the day indeed."

She assigned to them two rooms, in which a pair of lights, fed by butter, burnt the whole night. She took great care for the girls.

The merchant brought from his treasure the best jewels, precious stones and gold ornaments and with great taste, adorned the girls, just as people adorn the figure of the goddess Durgā during the month of October.

Three months passed, during which no question was asked as to who the girls were.

But at the expiry of the third month, when they had grown sufficiently familiar in the house, the merchant one day asked them, "You are here, my girls, at my house and looked upon as my daughters. May I ask you kindly to give me some account of yourselves. Where is your house? I travel in different countries and may perchance give you some clue to trace your parents. It is surely your cruel husband, who banished you in the lonely shoal in the mid-river.

The girls could not suppress their feeling but began to weep at the question. They then related through their sobs and tears their whole history without reserve. They gave an account of their parents,—how Bheluā met the young merchant and fell in love, how they both fled and went to the young merchant's house, where her father-in-law would not allow the couple to reside any more, owing to their scandalous flight from her father's palace. Then she described in heart-rending words the story of Abu Raja,—how that wicked man sent her husband away from his city on some pretext, how she marched to Jaiteswar in a boat of *man pavan* and at last how they drowned themselves in the midday at the confluence of four rivers, known as *Chougangā*.

The merchant wept, as he heard their sad story and all the people of his town expressed their great sympathy for

the girls. The old merchant and his wife put their wits together to decide what should be done for the girls. At last he settled to go on sea-voyage. He took the girls with him. He would first go to Kanchanpur (Bheluā's father's home). From there he would go to the city of Jaita, where Dhananjaya, the merchant, father of Menakā lived. He would make over the charge of the two girls to their respective parents. He took with him merchandise of various kinds, and thought that after having placed the girls under proper custody, he would go abroad for trading purposes. This was his programme. At an auspicious hour, he bowed low to the goddess Padma and set sail to his ships. So bound for Kanchannagar, he set out from his own home.

(Ll. 1-102.)

Now listen to what transpired next.

The wicked Abu Raja did not die, though his ship capsized. He returned to his city after having suffered much on the way. He discussed with his ministers as to what should be done. Then he appointed guards to watch over the ships that passed by the great river, on which his city stood. The ships of merchants, who went by that river for trade took fright and fled away, before Abu Raja's guards overtook them. But all could not escape. Woe to the ship, which fell at the hands of the guards. On pretext of a search, they plundered everything belonging to the ship. There our saintly old merchant approached the landing-ghat, unaware of the danger. The guards and informers, who kept watch, cried out, "Stop, Oh merchant, do not go. For if you move an inch from where you are, we will, according to the king's commands, take possession of your fourteen ships and sink them in the river." The merchant laid anchor there in order to save himself.

The guards came on board the ships and plundered everything that was there. Then they espied the two girls, bright as the sun and the moon and in great joy, they gave information to the Raja. Abu at once hied to the banks of the river with his ministers and other officers. He saw Bheluā and said, "What luck! I have not only obtained a gift but also a fee. I was madly searching for my lost lady and here she is with another, equally welcome. Now these two ladies will be the ladies of my heart. One will adorn the right side of my sleeping couch and another its left. Ah me! What have I not suffered these six painful months for that pair of star-like eyes and that treasure of black hair, profuse as the clouds? How many nights, have I not spent, dreaming of our joyous union? So long my wealth—nay the whole of my kingdom—was like poison to me, bereft as I was of my greatest fortune. Now God has at last been propitious to me." Saying so, he seized the girls by force and brought them to the palace of Rangchapur. The fourteen ships of the good merchant were taken away forcibly and he was placed in a half-shattered boat and ordered to leave the city. Just see the condition of the old merchant. He is now helpless as a straw in the stream as the reward of a pious wish to help others!

(Ll. 1-46.)

(12)

Now I shall, for a time, stop the narration of this part of the story and resume the account of the young merchant, Madan.

The skilful oarsmen of Madan, who steered the boat of *man pavan*, tried their best, at the risk of their own lives, and saved Madan, the merchant, at the junction of *Chougangā*. In that boat Madan carried the birds

Suka and *Sāri* and was accompanied by the trusted maid-servant Salukā. The young merchant travelled in that boat from place to place in quest of Bheluā, maddened by grief. Then as he went in his boat, one day he espied the old merchant passing along the river in a shattered boat, supplied him by Abu Raja. The boat could no longer stand the gusts of wind and the waves rose over its sides till the leaky barge was about to sink.

Madan saw the sad predicament of the old merchant and hastened, with his own boat, to the shattered one, belonging to the merchant. On his asking the oarsmen about the whereabouts of the old man, they gave him some account. Just at that moment, the boat was about to sink; the old man came out and took shelter in the boat of Madan with his people. Meantime, his boat was carried away by the winds and sank in the waters, near the next bend of the river. The old man gave a full account of the dangers he passed through—as to how he happened to save two girls of exceeding beauty from perishing on a lonely shoal near the junction of *Chougangā*. "The eyes of the girls were star-like and their hair as profuse and black as clouds." When he was thus giving a full description of the beautiful ones, Madan felt a sudden thrill in his heart and he eagerly asked the old man many questions about them. "Where did you take them? Why did you come in a shattered boat? Have they been drowned in the vast expanse of waters?"

"No, no, my young friend," replied the merchant, "they were not drowned, I took them to my own country. Myself and my wife took care of them as if they were our own daughters. For six months they lived at our house. But evil fate betook us afterwards. I wanted to do good to them, but did them harm instead, owing

to the inscrutable will of Providence. I took the right course but fell in a great danger. One day the girls gave me an account of their respective parents and began to weep and wished me to take them to their paternal homes. I ordered my fourteen ships to be ready and planned to go first to Kānchannagar (where the parents of Bheluā lived). On the way lay that Tiger of men, Abu Raja, and as I was passing along the river, which flows by the city of Rangchapur, he fell upon me, plundered all my treasures and forcibly carried the two girls. A thunder-bolt, as it were, fell on my head. All my ships were seized by that Rakshasa and the two girls are now living as prisoners in his palace."

Madan, with the old merchant, first went to his city in the boat of *man pavan*. Now when the saintly man was safe at his own home, the young man with Saluka set out for Rangchapur, the city of Abu Raja. Near a bend of the river, where the current was strong, he anchored his boat and discussed with Saluka as to the ways and means he would now adopt.

Saluka disguised herself as a *Dom* girl, selling fans and cane-baskets. She visited the palace of Abu Raja. She dyed her hair yellow, and bound them into a knot straight above the head in the fashion of a *Dom*-woman. She tied round her waist the flowing ends of her *sadi* and went into the inner apartments of the Raja's house. She said, "My husband's name is Sankar. My profession is to sell these fans and cane-baskets." This was how she introduced herself to the queens of Abu Raja. They purchased her goods according to their choice. Last of all, she paid a visit to Bheluā's room. She saw Bheluā, sitting with her friend Menakā. From her eyes streamed incessant tears, as she privately talked with Menakā. There was none in that big palace to feel

sympathy for her except Menakā. When Menakā wept, Bheluā, with the flowing folds of her *saḍi*, wiped away her tears and when Bheluā wept, Menakā tried to offer her solace. Thus both of them lived in great sympathy for each other, sorrowing over their lot, like poor Sitā in the prison of Rāvan, the Rākshasa-chief. When Bheluā saw Salukā, she felt like one, restored to life. She at once asked her information about her lord. But Menakā put her fingers on her lips, signing her to stop. Menakā asked Salukā, "What is the name of your husband, O *Dom*-woman? To which country do you belong? What is your mission here?" Salukā smiled at these queries and then introduced herself thus in a loud voice, "Our village is called Ujāni. I am the wife of Sankar, a *dom* by caste. I have come to this palace to sell my cane-baskets. You see how artistically these have been made. Rich men vie with one another to possess these fine baskets. If you want some, please purchase them without delay." Menakā took the gold necklace from her breast and gave it as price of several baskets and fans, that she purchased. She ordered the *dom*-woman to bring two fans more on her next visit. Salukā took leave of them, after having received a present from the betel-box; but she had already handed over a letter to Menakā along with the fan, which she pretended to sell to her. Menakā read the letter. The merchant said in it that he was living in that city with Salukā and requested Bheluā to let him know, through the maid-servant, what means she would now devise for escaping from the hands of the Rakshasa-chief. (Ll. 1-94.)

Now I will tell you of an incident that took place shortly afterwards. One day Menakā had a private talk with Bheluā, in the course of which she said, "Promise to me, girl, that you will marry the man, whom I shall

elect as my husband. If you will make this promise to me, all your dangers will pass away." Bheluā thought for a little time over the matter and then consented. Menakā then addressed her and said, "I have settled to marry this Abu Raja. He is handsome in features and possesses great powers and immense riches. In fact, there is scarcely to be found another man like him in the whole world. His riches are unbounded; his name is honoured and dreaded all over this vast country. I shall wear diamonds and jewels, being his queen, and you will be my dear companion."

Bheluā began to cry as she heard this and abused Menakā, saying that she was a vile and unchaste woman. "If you like," she said, "you may marry Abu Raja. For myself, I will drown myself in the river before I consent to marry the wicked Raja. There is that sharp steel-weapon in the house. I will put an end to my life with it. No more shall I go to the dancing hall." Saying so, she cried incessantly and wiped away her tears with the flowing end of her *sadi*.

Menakā said, "My friend, set your heart at ease and follow my advice. Try to be conciliatory to this Raja, however bad he may be. Tell him the next time he comes that you are willing to marry him and call him endearingly as the lord of your heart."

In the depth of night Abu Raja paid a visit to her chamber and said, "Come to my embrace, my lost treasure, found again. Hear me, dear lady of my heart, have some affection for me. I have already appointed an astrologer to settle an auspicious day. Know that within a short time, the marriage will take place. Do not kindly put off the date on some pretext or other, as you have been doing these many months. I have ordered a valuable string of pearls for you. I will spend my

night with you in the pleasure-house, which I have raised in the midst of our tank. How fine is your curling hair and how pleasing are your silvery eyes! I have six hundred wives in my harem. They will all be slaves to your wishes and you will reign supreme in the palace."

Bheluā.

"But before I consent to be your wife, I have some religious rites to perform. If you violate my vows, it will cause me great pain. I hope you will not do so. My friend Menakā knows all about my vows. She is here and you may know from her what they are. I am a merchant's daughter and our custom is to meet the bridegroom in the great sea. Wherever there is a marriage amongst our kinsmen, the bride and bridegroom go to the sea on board their merchant-vessels.

"So you are to marry me in the sea. There shall I offer you the present of the customary string of flowers, due to the bridegroom."

The auspicious day of marriage was fixed by Abu Raja and he left the chamber of Bheluā, thus settling all points.

"Hear me, Oh Salukā; last night Abu Raja called on me. I have given him word, agreeing to marry him. I have, besides, made a vow to the *Pirs*, promising to make them presents, if my object is fulfilled. To-morrow it will be announced in the public streets by a beat of drum that *Suka* and *Sāri* (male and female birds of the parrot-species) will be married and that two birds, thus to be united, will be purchased at a high price. The Raja's men will go forth in the country in quest of the

birds. Tell my lord to come with our *Suka* and *Sāri* to the city. Let him demand the fourteen ships and the treasure of a merchant, lately looted. Our enemy, the Raja, will not mind the price but, in order to please me, purchase the birds, paying down the price demanded.

"On receipt of the treasure and the ships, you are to go at once to the city of that saintly man, who has suffered so much and lost so much for the sake of us, unfortunate women. Give him back the fourteen ships and the treasure that he lost.

"Next proceed to the city of Kānchannagar. Let my lord stay near a bend of the river, where the strong current flows and yourself go alone to my father and deliver this message to him, 'Your daughter Bheluā, Oh old merchant, is in the deep sea, alone and in great distress. Separated from her parents, she is in a dire calamity and helplessly she floats like a straw on the waters. She has asked me to convey this news to you, crying all the time that she spoke. She has asked you to go and save her.'

"Next you are to go to Sankhapur, your own city and approaching the father of my lord, acquaint him with all facts. Tell him, 'Your dear son, Oh master, is in the milk-white sea, helpless and about to be drowned.' It is sure that the parents, however strict and relentless they may be, bear a secret pain in their hearts for their only son. They have not surely been able to give up their affection. Tell him, 'Go forth to save your son. In the milk-white sea his shattered boat is without a sail, without oarsmen; it floats like a straw and your only son is at the mercy of the waves. This city of yours is dark without him. The queen is shedding incessant tears and these hang on her eyes like a cob-web. She has, as it were, lost the most valuable

necklace of her heart. If you do not go and save him at once your son will be drowned.'

"Next go to the cities, where our friends are living. Issue invitation-cards, stating that the marriage of Madan and Bheluā will take place in the milk-white sea. Let them all attend the function. Invite all our friends and kinsmen in fitting language. Go everywhere," said Menakā, "but do not go to Jaiteswar. Go not to my brother. If he gets the least inkling of the matter, great danger may befall us. Alas, he fell into the great junction of four rivers, called the *Chouganga*. I do not know if he is alive. If he lives still, we may hope to see each other on some future day."

Salukā took leave of Menakā and Bheluā and went to the young merchant Madan and told him all that she was instructed to convey to him. (Ll. 1-107.)

(13)

When the auspicious time came at last, the Raja set out with his ministers and other officers. He took with him fourteen ships, manned by a promiscuous crew of musicians and drummers. One of the ships was manned exclusively by soldiers, who were in charge of magazine. Bonfires, rockets, squibs and fireworks of various kinds were taken in plenty. Large kettle-drums were beaten incessantly and people cried, "Victory to the Raja" on the eve of his marriage, which was to take place in the milk-white sea.

But the Raja, as he was about to start, saw evil omens on all sides. A blind fly sat on one of his eyes. Sneezes were heard in front; the women, while rejoicing on the happy occasion, found their voices choked for some mysterious reason. The people's words of exultation sounded like laments. A vulture came hovering in the

sky and sat on the top of the mast of the flag-ship. The ropes of the ships were torn by a sudden gust of wind. The ship which carried the auspicious articles of marriage suddenly capsized in the landing-ghat. Those things were lost in the river. The queens apprehended danger, and dissuaded the Raja from undertaking the trip that day, but he listened not to their good advice. In one of the ships, the Raja went with his ministerial officers and in another, Bheluā started with Menakā as her companion. The barber, the barber's wife, the priest and other people, whose services would be required at the function, started, too, in one of the ships. But the inauspicious signs on the eve of this happy occasion cast a shadow of fear and unrest on the minds of all.

Meantime what did Madan, the young merchant do? He started with fourteen ships and their treasure (got as price of the birds *Suka* and *Sāri*) and went to the city of the kind-hearted old merchant. The ships and all that belonged to him were returned and he was, besides, formally invited by Madan to attend his marriage with Bheluā.

Thence Madan went to the city of Kanchannagar. He remained in the ship, hiding himself from the citizens and sent Salukā to the palace of Bheluā's father. Salukā, with tears in her eyes, related the story of Bheluā's misfortunes to the inmates of the house. She tenderly appealed to the feelings of the parents, whose hearts, notwithstanding all outward indifference, were burning in grief for their dear girl. To the five brothers Salukā made a most pathetic appeal. "My heart breaks," she said, "at the thought that when you are living in all prosperity here, your sister is about to die in the milk-white sea. She, the

beautiful one, the beloved of all, is in the utmost distress."

The message had its effect and the old merchant, with his five sons, immediately started for the milk-white sea.

Then did Madan go to his own city of Sankhapur. The young fellow hid himself as before and sent Salukā to his father. She gave this message to him, "Your only son, revered sir, is about to be drowned in the milk-white sea. He is wandering in the vast waters in a shattered boat. I cannot tell you if he is still alive or all is over with him. You should try to save him, if he is not already lost for good."

Thence speedily did Madan go to other cities, the homes of his friends and kinsmen and distributed invitation-letters, wishing them all to be present at his marriage, which would take place in the milk-white sea.

Only two days were in hand; on the third day the marriage comes off. The merchants in all speed started for the milk-white sea. There all the chief men of the mercantile community met in a short time.

Raja Abu wonderingly saw ships on all sides, huge as mountains. "I never sent any invitation. The whole thing has been managed as privately as possible. I have brought Bheluā to this milk-white sea, without notice. Whence are all these ships assembled here?" thought he and became puzzled.

Then did Madan pass orders on his people to arrest Abu Raja with all his men. The barber and the barber's wife and the rest of the crew, who came to help in the marriage, were bound hand and foot. The Raja's ships were sunk in the sea and he, with his men, were brought to the great shoal, called the *Alangher char*.

The sandy land covered a space of 160 miles. There no trees, no plants grew; it was a waste land without habitation of men or even wild animals. If one happened to be in that vast area of sands, he could not find his way out. With the clothes they wore,—the long *dhuties*,—the men of the Raja were bound. The barber and the barber's wife (who had shown the long hair of Bheluā to Raja Abu) were bound with the ropes of the ship. The Raja himself shared the same fate. As he lay helpless and bound, with his face downwards, Madan approached him and said, "Now, Raja Bahadur, come and marry." In that condition he was left there.

Then with all humility, Madan described his misfortunes to the people of his community, assembled there. He took all of them, with imploring words to Sankhapur. His kinsmen and the father of Bheluā were pleased with him and the pride of high social status of Bheluā's father, which was the cause of all these unfortunate events, was now removed. He now consulted the astrologers for an auspicious day, as to when Bheluā should be formally given in marriage to Madan, the merchant.

The prow of the ship looked bright with its workmanship in gold and the sail, raised aloft, caused it to move with the speed of the winds. Maladhar was the head of the oarsmen. The young merchant ordered him to go swiftly to the city of Dhananjaya and there present him an invitation-letter.

Maladhar's boat went as speedily as an arrow. Dhananjaya, the father of Menakā and his kinsmen, all assembled at Sankhapur. Madan was to marry both the girls, Bheluā and Menakā. The loud music announced the happy event and the women sang festive songs. The merchant distributed gold and silver to the poor

people. Thus was the marriage celebrated. Young Madan was pleased with both his wives and spent his days in great happiness. The three were like one soul, one body. Salukā was rewarded with many valuable gifts. The kinsmen and friends went to their respective homes. Here ends the tale of Bheluā.

The Minstrel's Apology.

This is my humble prayer to the audience. May the president of to-night's congregation pardon me for my faults. For I am untrained and have surely committed many errors in music. The story of Bheluā is a long one, complete in five parts, and I am quite unfit to sing it. I am unacquainted with musical airs and modes. So I bow down at the feet of all and crave their pardon. Accept, sir, my humble *salaam*. Now, Oh brother host, give us some betels and tobacco and let us go back to our homes with thankful hearts. (Ll. 1-120.)

THE BALLAD OF RĀNI KAMALĀ DEVI

BY

ADHAR CHANDRA.

PREFACE.

The ballad of Rāni Kamalā Devi could not be recovered in full. Babu Chandrakumar De sent me, on August 30, 1925, a short summary of the contents of the two missing cantos from memory. The tradition, widely prevalent in the district of Mymensingh, is that as no supply of water came to the tank Kamalāsāgar, though it had been dug deep, the queen Kamalā Devi of Susang Durgapur, in conformity with a dream, dreamt by her husband, Raja Janakinath Mallik, descended to the bottom of the tank and gave up her life by performing some rites there. When these were performed, a rush of water came all on a sudden from underground, not only sweeping away the queen, whose body was irrecoverably lost, but also flooding the sides of the tank with its overflow.

The tradition, so far as the death of the queen is concerned, may be accepted as a historical fact. In those days, unnumbered were the instances of people, high and low, in this country, who sacrificed their lives as a result of prevailing superstitions—the most striking examples being supplied by the well-known *Sati*-rites. In the present case when the tradition is so widespread there can be no question as to the authenticity of the fact that the queen became a willing victim to superstition. We have heard innumerable stories in the countryside of poor coolies being sacrificed for propitiating the gods, when no supply of water was obtained from the underground in a newly excavated tank. The Kamalā Dighi exists to this day. Whether the rush of water,

described in the ballad, was due to some cunning priestly device or some natural cause, brought on at a later stage, by the persistent attempts of those engaged in the excavation of the tank, cannot be ascertained at this distance of time. The gods can only say if the water of Kamalāsāgar was produced by their grace.

Babu Chandrakumar De approached Mr. Saurendrakishore Raychaudhury, Zemindar of Ramgopalpur, Mymensingh, for being illuminated as regards the historical questions involved in this ballad. Mr. Raychaudhury supplied him with the following piece of information in his letter, dated the 3rd of April, 1925 :

" Kamalā Devi, about whom you want to know was a contemporary of Jehangir. She was the mother of Raghunath Singh, who got from that monarch the decoration of the title of Raja. She was the wife of Mallik Janakinath, an ancestor of the Susung Durgapur Raj family. The tradition of the place is that Mallik Janakinath heard an oracle in his dream, in conformity with which Kamalā Devi gave up her life. A part of the Kamalāsāgar still exists, the rest having been swallowed up by the river Someswari. Janakinath was a contemporary of Akbar. He lived towards the end of the sixteenth century. The baby referred to in the tradition is the son of Rani Kamalā Devi, who afterwards grew to be the illustrious Raja Raghunath Singh of Susung Durgapur. All noteworthy historical facts relating to Raja Raghunath are embodied in the 2nd part of my history of Varendra Brahmin Zemindars of Mymensingh."

Mr. Lethbridge furnishes the following account of him in his book, called the "Golden Book of India": " Mallik Janakinath was succeeded by his son Raghunath. The fragrant wood, produced largely in the Garo Hills,

called *aguru*, was in request at the Court of Delhi and Raghunath agreed to supply a quantity of *aguru* to Delhi yearly as a tribute, in return for the help of an Imperial Force, which enabled him to subdue his turbulent Garo subjects and for the title of Raja. The Emperor further conferred on Raja Raghunath the title of *Garo Tambi Munsavi* or Commander of Five Thousand."

The first canto, which is missing, contained a description of the marriage of Raja Janakinath with Kamalā Devi. The subject-matter of the first portion of the second canto may be thus summarised. The king and the queen lived happily for some years. One day she asked her husband as to what he would do for setting up a memorial for her in case she died earlier—in order to show that all his professions of love were true. The Raja said, " I promise to carry out your wishes, whatever they may be. Tell me what you would wish me to do." The queen said, " I will spin a *takuā* of thread in seven days and seven nights. You must have a tank excavated in my name, which will be of the size of the entire space covered by the length of the thread."

The queen, working night and day for the whole week, spun the same *takuā* of thread and the Raja ordered a tank of that size to be excavated at his town, to be called after her, the Kamalāsāgar. But the tank, dug at so much pain and cost, had no supply of water. The popular belief on this point was well-known, *viz.*, the ancestors of a man up to his fourteenth generation were doomed to hell, if the tank, dug by him, yielded no water.

Unlike most of the other historical ballads of Mymensingh, this one has a mythical and legendary element in it, which cannot obtain any credence. But we find in the ballad itself that the Raja had grown a maniac after the death of his wife. The subsequent developments

of the story may be taken as illusions, conjured up by his excited fantasy. The story is told in a graphic manner and with a candour, characteristic of the rustic poets. The legends, interspersed in this tale, have an old-world charm of rustic-poetry. The poet, Adhar Chandra, who composed this ballad, cleverly touches the delicate point as to how the queen met with her death. The Raja is described as having simply related the dream to his wife. He had not the heart to wish her to act up to it, he seems to have yielded to a superstitious faith in the dream, but even this he did not speak out to any one. He can by no means be accused of any deliberate act of cruelty. The ballad-maker does not even hint that he wished in the least that the queen should sacrifice herself. She herself became a willing victim. The Raja's great love for her is clearly in evidence in the succeeding events that transpired. If he did not actually come forward to stand in the way of his wife sacrificing herself, it was due to a lurking fear in his heart of incurring divine wrath for offering obstruction to what he considered to be an act of religious merit. This weakness on his part should not be severely judged, as we ought to make some allowance for the faiths and superstitions of the 16th Century. The queen believed that if no supply of water came to the tank, her husband's ancestors would all go to hell. Hence there was no other alternative on her part than to sacrifice her life in that tragic manner. Inspite of history and myth being blended together in this rustic song, it is a very enjoyable piece of popular poetry and I am not sure whether I should like its historical portion or its beautiful myth more. The latter adds a fascination to the tale and is as beautiful as the Idylls of the King, particularly the Mort de Arthur of Tennyson.

We have no information about Adhar Chandra, who composed this ballad. There is no doubt that it was composed in the beginning of the seventeenth century, since all such ballads, in commemoration of acts of local heroism, are composed immediately after their occurrence. In many cases the language of the original is gradually changed in course of their recitations through long generations. In the present case, however, the language is crude and rustic and does not seem to have undergone any substantial change.

In the Ballads such as Mahua, Dewan Bhabna and the Washer-maiden, the art of the rustic poets seems to be perfect in as much as superfluities find no place in them. The ballad-makers show an instinctive power of stringing together the essentials of the plot, leaving aside all irrelevant topics. In the present ballad, however, there is an element of rustic pedantry (as in Canto 7, Ll. 9-12, Canto 6, Ll. 17-20, 27-34) which has marred, to some extent, the compactness of the plot. The laments especially are monotonous and wearisome (Canto 6, Ll. 1-10), the ballad-maker's fondness for metaphorical phraseology, current in his rural districts seems to be often tinged with affectation, making his descriptions sink into dullness. This element, which does not strike so much in the original text, becomes apparent in my translation. In the Bengali original there is a grace and finish in the style which is missed when put in the garb of a foreign tongue. Inspite of this shortcoming the ballad has an irresistible fascination about it, due to the noble sacrifice of the queen, though inspired by superstition, and also to the romantic nature of the legend, described in it, which, like the Holy Grail of Tennyson, leaves an edifying effect on the mind.

The ballad of Rāni Kamalā Devi, so far as we have obtained it, is complete in 342 lines. I have divided it into 10 cantos.

I learn from various sources that this ballad was once very popular. I have not lost all hopes of recovering it in full.

The Ballad of Rani Kamala Devi.

(1)

In his big bungalow with twelve doorways, the Raja was having a quiet sleep, when, in the depth of night, he dreamt a dream.

The dream disclosed to his wondering eyes a land, resplendent with diamonds and pearls,—from which came floating an odoriferous and sportive breeze,—a land where it dawned at the glee cooings of the gold-winged cuckoo, —and where at the deep hours of night the birds sat on the boughs of trees and sang. And he dreamt of many wild things, besides.

He called the queen from her sleep and said, "Awake, my beloved, how long will you sleep? I am here, calling you. Open your eyes and see me.

"What a horrible dream have I dreamt, O queen! I cannot forget it for a moment.

"In the still and deep hours of night it seemed to me that all the stars were sunk in the sky and that the world was filled with an impenetrable darkness.

"Alas, why is it that the tank I have excavated in your name yields no water! I have dreamt a strange dream, which I am going presently to relate to you."

The queen lay in her bed,—bright and lovely as the full moon,—lost in deep slumber and the Rājā called her aloud sitting by the pillow, on which her head reposed. It was the last part of the night. The little lovely baby slept soundly by the side of its mother and

the Raja's eyes now rested on the child and now on the mother. (Ll. 1-18).

(2)

The queen awoke with a start and found the lord of her heart, sitting by her side. The quiet rest of the deep hours of night was broken and her eye-lids were still heavy with sleep. She said to her husband in sweet broken words,—"What is it, lord, that troubles you at such an hour as this? Strange, I see your eyes, full of tears. Tell me, my lord, what may be the cause?"

The Raja.

"A strange dream have I dreamt. It is about the tank, newly excavated in my city. That tank, O queen, may, after all, turn out to be a cause of our ruin. Though deep it was dug, no water has come out of it. I heard an oracle in my dream, saying that should you, my beloved, go to the bottom of the tank, water would come out of itself. I dreamt also as if, on hearing my words you descended to the bottom of the tank in slow steps. Scraps of unconnected scenes then presented themselves to my wondering eyes. I saw that all on a sudden there came a flood which swept you far away into the dark nether lands; as if the great flood from the underground came furiously rushing with foam at its mouth and inundated all the four sides of the tank. Then rose a terrible uproar as splashes were thrown up from some mysterious regions. I do not know, Oh queen, what evil spirit induced me to have this tank dug—to worry us all in this manner! My heart trembles in fear. Oh my dear queen, I do not wish my empire, nor my wealth, what pleasure will these yield to me if I lose you? (Ll. 1-22.)



"Some maids took sacred grass and rice for worshipping the gods and the others carried the queen's toilet articles on their head." P. 199.

(3)

The queen rose from her bed and slowly approached the big outer bungalow with twelve doorways. Her maid-servants were sleeping there. She called them out from sleep and ordered them to accompany her to the river-*ghat*. Some took golden pitchers, others cups of the same metal. Some carried towels, prepared by the artists of *Mecha*-country, others took valuable blue-coloured apparels. One maiden carried cups filled with incensed oil, the fragrance of which spread miles and miles afar. Some of them took the powdered *Gila*-fruit for cleansing the queen's body, others beautiful baskets, full of blooming flowers. Some maids took sacred grass and rice for worshipping the gods and others carried the queen's toilet-articles on their head. In that dark and dead hour of night they all went to the river-*ghat*. Above their head was the blue expanse of sky, which showed the stars, beautiful as the *Champa*-buds of golden hue.

Neither the sun nor the moon could have a peep into the face of the queen, which was then like an angel's, nor the people of the city who lay in profound sleep at that dark still hour before the dawn of the day. The maid-servants helped in washing her body with the *Gila*-fruit. Her hair was anointed with scented oil. The queen got down into the river for bathing. The maidens gently wiped the dirt off her body with the towels of *Mech*. When bathing was finished, they gave her a flame-coloured *Sadi* to wear. Seated on the bank of the Somai, she worshipped the gods with offerings of flowers, sacred grass and rice. And then she prayed. "Be witness, O river Somai; and O my husband, rest assured that I am going to obey the oracle you have heard and am prepared to give

up my life. Be witness, ye trees, standing still on the sides of the tank, and ye sun and moon, and O ye gods presiding over the world, bear witness too! whom else may I call at such a crisis of my life? For keeping the pledge of my lord, I am going to sacrifice my life. Strange that though dug so deep, the tank has yielded no water! The ancestors of this house up to to the fourteenth degree in ascent will visit hell. O, what a horror! O gods, I pray unto you all, save us from this danger. Save this glorious house but take my life, if indeed that is needed for it." With tearful eyes did this queen offer the sacred *bel*-leaves and flowers at the feet of the unseen powers. She repeatedly prayed that they might be propitiated and graciously inclined towards her lord.

After having offered the *Puja*, she returned home. No one, in that vast city,—outside her palace—knew of her holy bath in that deep hour of night. The night was fast wearing away and the gleam of morning was seen.

After return home, what did she do? The little baby was sleeping on a couch. She took it in her arms and gently kissed its sweet face a hundred times, shedding incessant tears all the while. "O my dear son," she cried, "You are to me what the prop is to a blind man. From to-day we shall never more see each other again." She suckled the child and, with a choked voice, said again, "Your beautiful face, dear child, which is like the moon, I will see no more." She then silently wept without uttering a word. Her heart was, as it were, pierced by a spear, but she bore her cruel pain mutely. (Ll. 1-53.)

(4)

From the depths of her heart, rose a plaintive appeal all secretly, "O lord of my heart, I leave this poor baby of

mine to your care." Inaudibly murmuring this, she addressed the old and trusted maid Suā and said, "To you, maid, I leave this baby—this treasure of my heart." She looked up to the birds, *Suka* and *Sāri*, whom she had brought from her father's house and asked them to teach the baby the sweet word 'mamma,' which they had learnt to recite. To all the servants of the house her silent request was that they might take care of one, who was far dearer to her than all the treasure of her palace. "That I leave this empire and the throne," she said with a sigh, "is not at all a matter of sorrow to me. But I feel a pain, which pierces my heart like a shaft, at parting with this child."

After weeping long, her eyes became dry. And then she made over the baby to Suā, the maid-servant. The attendants, male and female, stood aghast and did not know what would happen. A feeling of awe struck them and they cried in silence.

Then did the queen take a golden pitcher in her hand. In the flowing end of her *sadi*, she tied some sacred grass and rice. And then she hied to the side of that ill-fated tank. She, who had never been seen before outside the harem, was seen to-day by hundreds of men and women, assembled there to see the woeful sight of the hour. It was very early in the morning when the chief queen approached the tank. The morning-clouds above were tinged with a red colour and crows were cawing, seated on dry boughs of trees. The wind was blowing forcibly at times. A crow seemed to say to its mate, "What a pity! we shall never more see the face of the Queen-mother. The whole kingdom will, as it were, lose its eyes to-day and the throne will be void. Let us depart from this cursed land." Signifying some such resolve by their cawing, the crows hovered in the sky for a time, and then flew

far away. The people, assembled there, saw, with eyes uplifted, the strange spectacle. Some men said, "Alas, what a misfortune!" Others remarked that the virtuous king had lost his head. One man observed how foolish it was for the king to send the queen to that cursed tank for such a purpose. "It may be that he is going to lose her for ever. What good will the tank serve him? What, if there be no water in it? Let not the queen descend to the bottom of this tank." (Ll. 1-36.)

(5)

The queen, now in firm steps and with a calm majestic look, descended to the bottom of the tank. As she went down, she threw the sacred grass and rice on all sides from the flowing end of her *sadi*. The people were crying, "Alas, alas!" all the while. Then did she offer this prayer publicly. "If I am a chaste woman, and have lived true to the will of God, then may water spring up from the bottom of this dry tank. If I am chaste and have lived true to the will of God, may the water of the tank overflow its sides and may my people see this sight. If I am chaste, then fulfil, O God, the desire of my lord, the king. This object attained, it will not at all cause me pain, if I be swept away by a stream to the nether world." She sprinkled water from her golden pitcher on all sides. What an inexhaustible quantity of water did the pitcher hold! It seemed as if it would never get empty. Then did water gush out from the bottom of the tank and drench it gently together with the queen's beautiful feet. She continued sprinkling water and the water of the tank became knee-deep. She went on throwing water from her pitcher and the water of the tank swelled up to her neck. She raised

her hands up and still continued sprinkling water and her noble figure became gradually and totally submerged under water. Her dishevelled hair now floated over the ripples of the surface like the stream of the Ganges, flowing from the matted locks of the great God, Siva. Look there and see the flowing ends of her flame-coloured *sadi*, carried by the flood. The water of the tank rose higher and higher and inundated the sides of the tank, foaming in furious rage. The people who stood there began to lament loudly, saying "Alas, alas!" Whence came that great flood, no one could say. All the four sides of the tank were now flooded over. A roaring sound, which inspired awe, rose from underground. Alas, to what land the queen had gone, nobody could know. (Ll. 1-27.)

(6)

Then did the Raja throw himself on the ground, overwhelmed with grief, and begin to cry wildly like a mad man. The very trees, on the sides of the tank, deeply affected by the king's sorrows, seemed to shed their leaves in sympathy. The cows, in their sheds, and the birds, in their cages, were seen to drop silent tears. The cowherds, the horses of the stable and the elephants, men and beasts, all seemed to be alike stricken with grief. The pigeons of the palace and wild birds of the air stopped their chirpings and showed their grief, remaining mute all the while. The ministers, officers, the servants and maid-servants did not speak but shrank into a corner of their houses, overwhelmed with the general sense of grief. The mothers of that city did not care to suckle their babies but silently wept, leaving their dear ones aside. The good wives did not care for

their toilet but, with dishevelled hair, wept, forgetful of the presence of their husbands. In the gardens the flowers bloomed not but strangely faded away. Weep, weep, O river Somai, and sing the sad tale of how the goddess of the city left it for ever. O flood, roar out the tragic tale of how she was swept away for ever from the land of the living. The citizens cried, saying "To-day is the *Dasami*-day[1] for us, when our goddess has been taken away from the temple, to be drowned in the water."

The sky shines brightly with the moon and stars,—the house with its flower-garden and the river with her sailing-boats. The dark night is illuminated by a lamp; one's home, likewise, is brightened by the presence of the wife. The Raja saw everything dark before him, losing his beloved queen. "Ah my bird, where hast thou flown away, leaving thy golden cage." He cried day and night.

The Raja turned nearly mad with grief. He wandered night and day by the side of the tank, sometimes lying there, stretching his body like a dead man,—silently shedding tears. The ministers and officers met him often and advised him not to indulge in grief. He listened to their advice but, at the end, simply said, "Alas, alas!"

What becomes of the house, when the lights are out! What is the value of a twig deprived of its floral treasure? What good is served by a tank, in which there is no supply of water? What is the value of the body without life? And how does the hole look when its pigeon has fled away? Like all these and worse than all, is a man's house, deserted by his wife.

[1] On the Dasami day the image of Durga is thrown into a river or some adjacent tank.

"Am I not like a bird, whose mate has been killed by the arrow of a hunter? Alas, who has taken away the diamond of my heart, worth seven times the value of this my kingdom? What shall I do with it and with my riches?" Thus did the king lament day and night. He would not touch food, nor drink water.

Adhar Chandra sings this song of sorrow. The grief of the Raja was so great that the very stone melted at the sight.

The Raja walked by the sides of the tank, and sometimes with vacant look entered the deep jungly land of Durgapur, foolishly believing that he might perchance meet his queen there. But days and weeks rolled by; she no more appeared before him. "What is the good of this nice hall with twelve doorways, that I have built? Woe be to my pleasure-house, built in the midst of a tank, where we enjoyed each other's company in summer! That house saddens my heart with the sight of its forlornness and desertion."

One month passed in this way. The waters of the tank Kamalāsāgar looked dark and transparent, as on the day when the queen was carried away by the flood. Suddenly an idea came to the king's mind. He called all the divers of the land and ordered them to get down and bale out the water of the tank. "Some evil spirit made me exacavate this tank, which has caused my ruin. O my good men, bale out the entire water with *seyat* (a vessel) so that I may make a last attempt to find her out. Six thousand and four hundred men were employed to empty the tank of its liquid contents. For nine days and nine nights they applied their whole strength to carry out the king's command. But though they employed their whole might, not a hair-breadth of water

decreased. The tank remained full as ever. The coolies in terror fled away. The vast body of water, baled out of the tank, flooded the shoals of the river Somāi. All the neighbouring land was drowned and the houses of the poor ryots were swept away. They fled to distant lands in fear. But still the dark waters of that ominous tank did not decrease by an inch. The current of the Somāi flew in a contrary course and the foaming flood reached the very tree-tops. (Ll. 66.)

(7)

Now listen to what transpired next, to add to the wonders of this wonderful tale.

The Raja again dreamt a dream.

There, in the great hall, with twelve doorways, the king was sleeping. In the depth of night, he dreamt a dream. He was half-awake and half-asleep ; and in that semi-conscious condition it appeared that he vividly saw his queen slowly approach him and take her seat by the side of the pillow, on which rested his head. The queen spoke :—

" O my dear lord, listen to my sad tale. I am passing my days in the nether world in great sorrow.

A sound sleep in the night gives refreshment to the soul. I never enjoy the blessings of such a sleep.

When one's baby is near its mother, how happy she is!

How cool is a sweet mat in the summer and how happy one feels, when, in a dark room, light comes suddenly to dispel the darkness!

Sweeter than all this is the company of a husband to a woman!

I have lost both my husband and my child. How miserable am I! I am maddened with grief, like a wild

bird, desiring to break open the bars of its cage, I yearn to break through my present environment and have my child once more near my bosom ! How can I live without him !

Now, my beloved, kindly fulfil my wishes, of which I am going to tell you. Build a house on a side of the tank. Let the maid-servant Suā spend the night in that house with my child, mentally wishing for my return. Let not even the tailor-bird, nor a fly, know of this. Everything should be done secretly. Let not the citizens have any inkling of this. I will come to see the child in the deep hour of the night if this is done. For one full year you must not shed a single drop of tear for me. I will come every night and suckle the child. After one full year both of us will meet again, and if, for this one year, I can suckle the child every night, it will grow to be as powerful as Indra, the god of heaven."

There she stood before him, — not a whit stouter, not a whit thinner, exactly as she was before. Her complexion shone with the same lovely grace ; — the same flame-coloured *saḍi* she wore ; the very ornaments that once adorned the body of the chief queen added the same lustre to her graceful figure. Her flowing *saḍi* waved in the air, playing with her dishevelled hair as before, and her eyes bore the mild light of stars, as before. The same sweet voice — the perennial delight of the king's ears, — sounded like the musical note of the cuckoo.

The Raja awoke from his sleep wiih a start and looked around. He had already become half-mad for grief. But from that day it appeared that he completely lost his senses. The interview was in the land of dreams. Could it ever be brought within the range of realisation ?

(Ll. 1-38.)

(8)

When the morning dawned, he gave orders to his men to build a spacious house on one side of the tank. The architects prepared strong posts of the *sāl*-wood and the roof was covered with straw of the *ulu*-species. They built the house in one day, as the order of the king was to have it done with the utmost promptitude. The walls were covered with fine mats and were so thick that even a fly could not enter. There was not a pore left, through which an ant could pass, though it was a straw-bungalow. In the day-time not a streak of light could penetrate into the hall, nor the wind had any access there by night. Thus was the house made, packed like a box. In the centre of the hall was a bedstead of ivory. A valuable mat was spread over it, with a goodly curtain and a number of pillows. A fan of mica and a pitcher, full of water, were placed by the side of the bed. The bungalow was furnished with all necessary things, required for a sleeping room. In a corner, burnt a lamp, fed by butter.

The Raja sent the nurse Suā there with the child on the very first night. A betel-box was supplied her. There was, besides, a supply of sandal and sweet-scented *chua* and the bed was milk-white. Many a night came and passed away ; and one day the Raja asked the maid-servant, " Have you, O nurse, observed anything happen any of these nights ?" The maid-servant replied in slow accents, " Strange sight I see my lord every night, the queen comes and suckles the child at the deep hour of night. The figure is exactly the same, not a whit stouter, not a whit thinner is she. The same bright and lovely colour,—the same curly hair, waved by air, the same ornaments, adorning her person, and the same

flame-coloured *saḍi* which she used to wear. She spends the whole night with the child and suckles it. It is she, I solemnly avow to you, my lord,—your wife, our gracious queen, and none other. The doors are bolted, the windows are shut. In the morning she goes away. Strange and mysterious are her appearance and disappearance. I cannot find out how she comes and goes. (Ll. 1-38.)

(9)

The Raja, who had been known for his wisdom, acted foolishly that day. He asked the nurse to come to the new house with the child that day before nightfall. Only a day had remained to complete the year and the Raja missed a great opportunity, losing his patience for that one day.

In a golden box were preserved betels, scented *aguru*, *chuā* and sandal. The nurse came to the room with the child, rather early that day. She shut all the windows and doors. On the bed she slept with the baby.

In the midnight the Raja did not find any peace of mind. He had not a wink of sleep that night. Slowly did he come out of his great hall and wandered about the side of the tank. The moon and the stars glanced at him from the sky. He slowly approached the new bungalow. There he saw flower-plants, standing still with their soft-petalled treasure and not gaily playing with the air. People all around were merged in deep sleep. The citizens slept soundly in that vast town, but its lord had no sleep in his eyes. He bemoaned his lot, walking to and fro like a mad man.

The cuckoo suddenly sent a shriek through the sky and left its nest. At that hour the Raja lost his sense. (Ll. 1-22.)

(10)

Who ever saw a stone at the top of a mountain, which could illuminate, by its brilliance, all the fourteen regions of this universe? Who ever saw a lamp, so bright, that, lighted in one house, it could dispel the darkness of all the houses in the world? The sun is that brilliant stone and that great lamp. He, the Lord of the day, bathed in the Eastern Sea and found a chariot ready for him. He would presently ascend the chariot and begin his journey through the world. The horses of that chariot were milk-white and their wings were fire-red. The speed of the horses surpassed that of the winds. So quick it was that they could scarcely be seen. The palaces of the great luminary were made of mica, which sparkled like fire. The god of the day was about to ascend his chariot—he was going to meet his consort, the Dawn.

At that hour of junction of day and night, the Raja stood at the gate of the new house with his hair loose and wild. He cried hoarsely, "O nurse, open the door and show me but once my queen." At the sound of his foot-step, the queen herself came out, opened the door and stood before him.

"O my life!"—more the king could not say but clasped the queen to his breast.

The Queen.

"O my beloved, O my king! Allow me to depart and leave my hands. The period of my curse is over. I must go back to the abode of the gods, from where I came."

Saying so, the queen freed herself from his embrace and disappeared. The Raja, when he rose from his

stupor, found a fragment of her flame-coloured *saḍi* in his hand,—this was torn in his attempts to keep her.

Adhar Chand, the poet, is sorry and laments thus :— "Why, Oh Raja, did you become impatient ? Else, your son, the prince would have been as powerful as Indra, the God of heaven." (Ll. 1-22.)

THE END.

THE ADVENTUROUS CAREER OF A YOUNG DACOIT.

PREFACE.

"The adventurous life of a young dacoit" was collected by Babu Behari Lal Ray from Mymensing and sent to me on the 22nd of September, 1925. The ballad is called "Maniktārā" in some localities, after the name of its heroine. Babu Behari Lal Ray wrote to me that he took infinite pains to collect it from different places of the district. It is complete in three parts, of which the first part only was secured by him. "The remaining two parts," wrote Behari Lal on the 22nd of September, 1925, "will take some time to collect, as it will involve journeys of a difficult nature; for the minstrels who know it live in widely distant localities." Two days after, on the 25th of September, Behari Lal died of failure of heart all on a sudden. He had been suffering for a long time from chronic fever, and the task to which the University appointed him required him to tour in unhealthy places of mofussil in his very delicate state of health. He died in harness, as it were, having worked till the last day of his life in the cause of the collection of old Bengali ballads.

It is very doubtful if the remaining parts of this ballad will ever be collected in future. I do not know from what villages Behari Lal had collected the first part. I expected that, as usual, he would furnish me with such information, later on. But there is no means, now available, to ascertain the localities where this ballad is sung. I will, of course, try my best to collect the remaining parts.

This ballad does not seem to be a very old one. Though it is composed in a colloquial language, spoken by the rustics of the backward villages of Eastern Bengal, and there is no attempt at embellishing it by felicitous

classical words, yet the rhyme seems to be more regular than that of our earlier ballads. The words here are rugged and coarse, befitting the illiterate peasantry of Eastern Bengal; but the lines conform to the regular cæsura and pauses of the *Payār* metre, though they do not always follow the canon of 14 letters a line. The classic influence had reached the masses at the time of the composition of this ballad so far as to produce a rough impression of the developed *Payār*-metre on the rustic poet,—which accounts for the somewhat crude regularity of its measured metrical sound. But the ballad was composed certainly before the advent of the English. There is no indication of any European influence in it and no trace of western ideas in the description of village-life. Trade was carried on, at the time, chiefly by a system of barter and we find the currency of a very large number of *cowries* in ordinary transactions of life. A ferry-boat, for instance, sometimes charged as much as 12,800 *cowries* from each passenger, which shows scanty or no use of coins in those days in our villages (Canto I, Ll. 37-43). This state of things existed before the country passed into the hands of the British. The villages of Bengal and her rivers, in those days, were haunted by gangs and the passengers feared the pirates more than the wild storm that raged in the waters of the dreaded Brahmaputra. All this takes us to the declining days of the Muhammadan rule, when the Imperial power was not adequate to cope with the revolting chiefs or even the marauding gangs, who oppressed the people, unchecked and fearless. This ballad was composed not later than the middle of the 18th century.

Women of those days were sometimes expert archers; nay, they even learnt wrestling and other masculine games—a fact which we find proved not only by

evidences of the ballads but also from various other circumstances. We have found in the ballad of Feroz Khan how Sakhina fought in the field of Kella Tazpur against the Imperial Army in the 17th century.

There are very many other curious facts on which the ballad throws light. The mode of operation of the robbers,—how they killed innocent wayfarers,—how, with the help of ropes, tied secretly to the ferry-boats, they made escapes with their booty after the boats were made to capsize in the big rivers with passengers and how the booty was buried underground,—all these are vividly drawn in interesting sketches.

We have found names of two poets in the colophons of the ballads—*viz.*, Amir and Jamait Ulla. Both of them write in the same strain and it is difficult to find any special feature by which the composition of the one may be distinguished from that of the other. By far the greater portion of the ballad is the composition of Jamait Ulla, and Amir has so wonderfully adapted his composition to the style of the other poet that the ballad, as a whole, shows a compactness and homogeneity in style and diction. I am at times led to believe that Amir is the name of the minstrel, who sang the ballad at one time. We find it on occasions that the rhapsodists sometimes put their names in the colophon claiming the dignity of authorship. It is rather difficult to say anything definite on the point, until we get some more recensions of the ballad.

The chief excellence of this ballad does not lie in its poetry, though occasionally we meet with passages of much ingenuity; nor is the ballad noted for any dramatic quality. It is more like a narrative, giving details of the life of some of its chief characters,—the main compliment being due to the graphic domestic and social sketches with which the ballad abounds. Though

the accounts of particular episodes are long, they are not wearisome or verbose, so that there is a sustained interest, preserved from the beginning to the end. The poets display a good deal of humour in many passages. The portraiture of the physician Tinkari (Canto IV, Ll. 80-96) is drawn with considerable skill. The quaintness of the country-dialect, with its pointed and forcible words, sometimes verging on the slang, gives to the figure of the village-quack an amusing interest, hardly conveyed in my translation. The much-vaunted efficacy of the three pills, one blue, one red and one white,—the ingredients with which they are to be swallowed, the physician's diagnosis and the almost immediate failure of his prognostications are meant to hold the physicians as a class up to ridicule. During the Muhammadan times, all references to physicians in our literature are ungracious and even acrimonious. I do not know how to account for this sarcastic treatment of physicians as a class. In the Chaitanya Bhagavata, written towards the end of the 16th century, Chaitanya Deva is represented as satirising the physician Murari Gupta over his knowledge of drugs and pills, though the latter was a profound scholar. Kavikankan about this time gives a sketch of physicians which is far from complimentary. His great European contemporary, Bacon, wrote in his essays, "Physicians cure diseases as the sailors bring wind by whistling." The thing is that in good old days the countrypeople-believed more in the rules of diet and habit for preserving their robust health than in the physician and in his patents. In the present case, the use of tamarind as a sequel to swallowing pills prescribed by the physician is significant. It suggests the conclusion that the village-doctor often used poisonous drugs and it is well-known that tamarind is an antidote to poison. The village-people would not

wait patiently for their cure for a reasonable time. When they paid something to the doctor, they wanted instantaneous cure. I know a physician, who was once assaulted by the illiterate relations of a patient in a distant village of Tipperah, because he had taken a rupee but could not effect the remission of fever in three days. On my asking how his predecessor in the profession was so popular with the village-folk, the physician said, "He was a quack, sir. He used *mitha bish* (poisonous drug), the result of which was immediate remission of fever. In order to prevent the patient's temperature coming down to a sub-normal point or his succumbing to the effect of poison, tamarind and other antidotes were prescribed. If the patient died in spite of them, the good name of the physician still remained intact. The village-people would say that the treatment was all right, that the doctor caused a remission of fever by his potent drug, but that the fellow died of sheer weakness, as he was destined to die. These villages do not require a physician, sir, they want quacks."

The poet Jamait Ulla sometimes aims his humorous attack at some vulnerable points of Hindu rituals with considerable effect (Canto VI, Ll. 24-30).

The love-scene introduced in Canto V (Ll. 36-108) breathes an air of vigorous country-spirit and freedom without showing any trait of undignified coquetry or lack of feminine modesty in the heroine. Life, in the lower stratum of society in Bengal is even now sometimes healthier than in the upper grades. This will be evident from many passages of the ballads. The characters are bold, natural and full of the vigour of life. There is of course wickedness rampant in the incidents of the story ; the hero himself is a notorious robber-chief and the heroine, too, so far as we can guess from this part of the ballad, is one of his

accessories. While taking recourse to stratagems and manœuvres for achieving wicked ends or engaged in a piece of daring and downright robbery, Kanu and Vashu are undaunted figures, whose actions are characterised by a superabundance of masculine energy, untrammelled by any hesitancy or wavering. Maniktārā's character is just rising into prominence in this part, indicating the future achievement of some superb point of glory; but we have not yet secured material to see its flowering point. As the ballad is sometimes called by the name of Maniktārā, we believe that the heroine cut a prominent figure towards the end.

While the accounts of villainous deeds, perpetrated by the hero and his colleagues become sickening to a degree, the character of Vashu's mother, sketched in a few lines, redeems the atmosphere and shows what spiritual grace and moral apprehensions adorn the character of our country-women. Vashu was dearer to her than life; yet when she heard of his wicked adventure, she sighed and said that it would have given her a greater relief to behold the corpse of her son than to see him turn a robber (Canto 4, Ll. 71-72). Her great grief at the discovery of her son's villainy blasted her life and she died of a broken heart.

This ballad has many points in common with a modern romance, though its authors were thoroughly illiterate and belonged to an age when romantic narratives of this kind were not generally composed.

This ballad is complete in 832 lines. I have divided it into ten cantos.

16th November, 1925. D. C. S.

The Adventurous Life of a Young Dacoit.

(1)

Direct to the north from here is a river. But 'river' is a poor name for this vast reservoir of water—looking like seven (mythical) seas, blended together. This vast sheet of water is called the Brahmaputra. It seems as if a Brahmadaitya (the fabled goblin) roars night and day from the bottom of the river. How grand is the river to behold !

One may see its bank from the *Ganja-ghat*, but the other bank is beyond the range of human ken. It seems that the river has one boundary-line, but has none to indicate the other side.

When storm blows over it, the ordinary boatman dares not steer his boat across the river. The waves, high as house-tops, fall and break, foaming furiously.

The little tailor-birds leave their nests and scream over it, struck with fear. Many a tree is observed floating down the stream, drifting towards the eastern hills.

But this turbulent temper is set at rest, when no storm blows over the stream. Then one may see it running a quiet course, without sound,—smoothly flowing from bend to bend—when through its transparent water the boatmen and rowers are seen merrily plying their boats and pinnaces. When the air is still, the river has scarcely a ripple on its surface but looks plain like a flat can.

On the bank of the river is a landing-place named *Ganjer-ghat*, and close to this, there is a mart, known

as the *Ganjer-hāt*, held regularly thrice a week. The mart is a flourishing one, astir with brisk traffic. People every day assembled there, having crossed the river by the help of ferry-boats. They came to the mart in the morning, hired a house for the day and after making purchases, cooked their meals and passed the night in the house and departed the next morning. Hundreds of such ferry-boats and small fishing canoe-shaped vessels might be seen day and night, carrying men to the mart.

These boatmen are recklessly bold—they do not care a fig for storm or wind. When the river is furious, they face it like bold soldiers and when, as ill luck would have it, their boats capsize, they do not fear at all to meet with a watery grave.

They charge heavily from passengers. Heaps of cowries—regular hills of them—the passengers have to pay to the boatmen, in return for the risky service, rendered by the latter, namely, carrying them across the river. I will calculate the charge in detail. One *pan* is equal to 80 *cowries*, and a *kahan* is equal to 16 *pans*. A passenger is required to pay 10 *kahans* (12,800 cowries) per trip. Even after this heavy charge is met, their lives are not secure in the boats. Some are carried safe to the other bank of Sherpur by the grace of God, but instances are not few when passengers get drowned. From *Ganjer-hāt* to Sherpur, as already stated, the ferry-charge is 10 *kahans*. Hence this port of the river is called *Dashakahaniā*.

The ferry-boats have also other dangers to face. Thieves often rob the passengers of their money and jewels, and before they can reach Sherpur, they are sometimes cruelly murdered by wicked gangs. Among these boatmen, however, all are not dishonest; but many of them feel no scruple whatsoever in thrusting their

knives into the breasts of people and seizing their property, even in broad daylight. Sometimes they forcibly plunder all jewels and other valuables of the passengers; they take them to the very heart of some dark and shady jungle, and leave their poor victims there, all naked and in abject forlornness. Sometimes these dacoits cut the throats of these people by sharp swords, sometimes they rend their skulls by strokes of axe and fling their body into the river, binding them, hand and foot, with ropes. They seize the valuables and ornaments from the persons of their victims and loot their property by breaking open their trunks and baskets. All these are duly made over to the leader of the gang. (Ll. 1-56.)

(2)

Close to the *Ganjer-hāt* lived a barber, named Vishu, who had, at one time, pursued the avocation of a boatman. He had his wife and five children. So poor was he that he had not a cowrie in his hand, to provide his family with food and raiments. He could not secure a bundle of straw for repairing the roof of his little house or wooden posts for fixing the thatch-walls.

Vishu, in his distress, had no other resource, left to him, than to live by begging. But even though his wife, too, became a beggar, their joint earnings were quite inadequate. Of the five sons, Vashu was the eldest, aged twelve, but he had not yet learnt any trade. Then came disaster upon disaster on the poor family. The second son Kushai unfortunately got drowned in the Brahmaputra. The third Dāshu was one day carried off by a crocodile from near the landing-ghat. The fourth one, in his attempt to climb a tree, fell down on the earth and died of a mortal wound that he had got by his fall. The youngest suffered long from infantile diseases, till he,

too, was finally relieved of all trouble by the hands of death.

Vishu became almost blind with tears. Many a time he blamed his Maker for creating him and found fault with His dispensation.

"You have made me a poor wretch without a cowrie in my hand. We starve for want of diet—which no doubt you can see. You were gracious enough to grant me a valued treasure in my children. When the five children would talk, their merry voices would make me forget, for the time, the stings and anguishes of poverty. Now all the lights you have put out, save only one. I do not know when that one, also, you will take away. This Vashu of mine is the only lamp of the house. If this, too, is blown out, it will be all over with me.

"Alas, thou cruel Sporter, why dost thou play with human heart in this manner? If thou gavest them out of thy grace, why hast thou taken them away again? Thou hast no regard for the feelings of the old parents. I cannot bear my grief. Why dost not thou, O God, take me away from this world, to heal my bruised heart for ever?"

Often would he sit on the bank of the river and lament in this way. He became so absorbed in grief that he forgot that it was a treacherous bank, which, yielding to the force of the under-current, would sometimes crumble down unwares; and one day while thus grieving, the ground beneath his feet gave way and fell into the bosom of the river with a violent crash. The boatman Vishu was drowned in this way.

Losing her husband after all the bereavements she had already suffered, Vishu's wife became almost insane with grief.

"All the grim sufferings of poverty I bore with patience, picking up strength at the sight of my husband. I have now lost him, too. I will hang myself on a tree in yonder jungle and put an end to all this misery. If I cannot hang myself, there is the cool breast of the river, where I will find rest, as my husband has done."

Grieving in the above manner, she left her home and went towards the neighbouring forest. Vashu, at this time, called " mamma " from behind. She turned her eyes back and saw the lovely face of her son. The sight filled her heart with affection. She forgot the great bereavement and also that she had nothing to eat at home. Amir, the poet, says, "Why should you now give up your life? Return, O mother, to your cot and wipe away your tears."

The widow, with her young son, begged from door to door, and kind-hearted men doled away small gifts in charity. She did not leave her cot, nor her little son. Like a bird, hatching its young one under its wings, she attended to her charge with utmost devotion.

(Ll. 1-58.)

(3)

Near her little cot lived fishermen and Kochas. She had no kinsman, no relation, in the neighbourhood. No parents had she, nor any brother, under whose roof she might expect to live for a few days.

One, who is deprived of all help from outside, receives help from unexpected quarters. From among the Kochas, a woman, whom people called Kanu's mother, came forward, full of compassion at her distress. Vashu's mother and Kanu's mother became bound in fast friendship. Kanu's mother considered this friendship as god-send to her. Kanu and Vashu

were nearly of the same age, Kanu being older by three years only. Kanu had stepped into his twentieth year; streaks of thin moustache had just appeared on his chin. He became now Vashu's guide and friend in all matters, leading him sometimes to evil ways. Vashu's mother tried to dissuade him, but he heeded not his mother's advice.

Obliged as she was to Kanu's mother for pecuniary help, rendered now and then, she could not too strongly insist on her son's dissolving all connections with Kanu.

The heart of Kanu's mother was full of kindness for her friend, and Vashu's mother knew this very well.

She prepared almost every day some dainty dishes to entertain Vashu's mother. Seldom did she visit her friend when in her towel she did not tie some pulses or rice for her, nor brought a little cup filled with oil. Fresh brinjals, chillies and fruits of garden—she brought every now and then and presented to Vashu's mother. Behind her house were large pastures, where she used to milk the buffaloes and this she stored in bamboo-cups and brought to Vashu's mother as her little gift from day to day.

Vashu's mother, however, did not sit idle, relying on her friend's help, but worked as best as she could. She spun thread for the nets of fishermen and husked rice; this she did not consider beneath her dignity, though she earned only a little by these stray occupations. Sometimes she got a quantity of rice-dust and at others some small fishes by her own labour.

She spent her days in this way, feeding herself all the while with the hope that her child Vashu would soon grow into manhood and relieve her of all her sufferings. "Then will our wants be removed and we shall once more be blessed with prosperity and happiness," thus did she think within herself.

Now Vashu became a strong lad of twenty. He delighted in sports, jumped and played in the village-paths and woods like a wild horse. Kanu, the *Koch*, became his *guru* and Vashu, the barber, became Kanu's worthy disciple. They two were utterly reckless and feared not men or beasts. They walked about, twisting their moustache in truly gallant fashion.

Behind Vashu's cot there were some fig-trees. The people of the locality said that these trees were haunted and hence no one dared enter the wood land at night for fear of being molested by ghosts.

One midnight when Vashu's mother was enjoying a sound sleep, she became suddenly disturbed by a voice which awoke her from sleep.

"Arise, O Vashu's mother, and look at the sky. You consider that your cot is very secure with its wooden posts and thatches. Not at all. If the storm comes, those will be shattered in no time and your cot will be swept away from the earth, leaving no trace of its existence. Then, O Vashu's mother, where will you put your head and find a refuge?"

The barber-woman became frightened. She caught hold of her sleeping son and held him tightly in her arms. Then gathering a little courage, she addressed the voice, which she believed to be a ghost's and said:—

"In this depth of night you are calling me from behind this house. Who may you be? If my cot is to be swept away by inclement winds, what can I do to prevent it? How can I resist my ill-luck? God has taken away my children, one by one, and I know not if more evils are in store for me. But is it worthy on your part to joke with a woman in her distress, living in this shattered cot?"

"But, aunt, why should you be angry with me? You seem not to have known me. Your son Vashu calls me Kanu Dada. I am his companion and friend and my mother, too, has been bound fast in solemn ties of friendship with you. I expect you to regard me as your son. Why should you be angry with one, who knows and respects you as his mother? I have got some work to do at this dead hour of night. Many ripe fruits are there in the woody-land. I have come to take Vashu with me to gather those and eat them at ease together. Do not fear, aunt. Just look at the sky, the wind has blown away the storm that had filled the sky a little before the black clouds, that had darkened the atmosphere,—have all gone away and left the sky bright and clear. Rouse Vashu, Oh dear aunt, from his sleep and let him accompany me."

The barber-woman was ashamed of her conduct and regretted having used rude words to her friend's son. She changed her tone and said in an apologetic voice, "How could I know, dear Kanu, that you were seated on that haunted tree. I was sleeping and was in a semi-conscious state, when I spoke unkind words to you. Do not, dear Kanu, take offence, and you must also excuse me for not complying with your request. I cannot allow Vashu to go out of the house at this hour of midnight. You know that Vashu is to me what the prop is to a blind man. He is dearer far than a rib of my breast. While I walk in the village-paths, it is his lovely face which I recollect and thus do I gather strength to bear the hard lot of day-time. In the night he is my treasure, and I cannot spare him for a moment. Come in the morning and I will allow him to go with you wherever you may wish to take him."

When she was speaking, Vasu was roused from his sleep by his mother's voice. He said to his mother, "With whom, mother, are you talking in this lonely hour of midnight ?"

Vashu's Mother.

"Kanu has come ; he has climbed up that haunted fig-tree and is talking from there."

At these words of his mother, Vashu at once sprang up from his bed and opening the door of his hut, ran towards Kanu and soon overtook him ; and having embraced Kanu, he asked him in all eagerness, "Why, brother, what is the reason that has made you visit this house of ours at night ? "

Kanu replied, "I came to take you with me, but your mother is not willing to part with you. There is the difficulty."

Vashu said, "Don't, brother Kanu, worry yourself about that. I am presently going with you and what you have got to eat I will share with you."

He said to his mother, "Arise, mother, shut the door. A brother is going with his brother. Why should there be any foolish anxiety over this ? "

Vashu left home with Kanu. Vashu's mother spent the remaining hours of the night in sleepless anxiety.

Struck with fear and anxiety, she lamented thus :

"You came to this cot, Oh cruel boy, like an enemy to steal away the peace of my mind ! Your face is my only consolation. I hide you like a treasure in my breast. But, foolish lad, you have treated me like a beast or a savage and cast me away without any respect for my feeling." "Oh Sylvan deity, I pray unto you, keep

my boy safe and secure. I will worship you with fried oat, molasses and rice. My prayer to you, Oh Goddess Subachani, is to keep my boy safe and I will worship you with betel and betel-nuts."

Just at that moment an owl screamed from an adjacent tree-top. Vashu's mother, in all haste, prayed the bird to stop its ominous moping. "I will roast a *Boâl*-fish for you, Oh black owl, and also burn a *shail*-fish to offer you, if, through your grace, he, the treasure of my heart, returns home all hale and hearty."

Vashu's mother wept all night, lamenting in this strain. I have no adequate words to describe her grief. It was when the raven cawed from the house-top, indicating the advent of morn that her eyes closed, yielding to the influence of sleep. (Ll. 1-100.)

(4)

Walking to a considerable distance, Kanu sat under a tree and disclosed his object to Vashu.

"You know the old Brahmin and his aged wife, who live in a hired house on yonder river-bank. They are going to cross the river and go to the other bank before it dawns. I shall have to carry them thither in the ferry-boat belonging to Sona, the boatman. You must be my companion in my trip; so hurry up, lad, lest the night should pass away."

Vashu.—"Why should Sona, the boatman, make over the charge of his boat to you? The hire he might enjoy himself? Why should he give up his share?"

Kanu.—"Oh dear boy, you do not know, for these four or five days Sona Majhi has been down with fever; for another four or five days, his boat-hooks will remain fixed to the ground, as there is none to ply it.

"Now hear my plan. I will carry the old Brahmin-couple in the boat, and somehow the boat will capsize near the treacherous sands of the river at Ganjer hāt. I had a peep into his gold mohurs, ornaments and other valuables last evening. They are indeed a tempting sight."

Vashu.—"But, brother, it is all right; when the boat will capsize we two together, with all the valuables, will get drowned, as well, in the mid-river. The sands are treacherous there; no one can escape from them, if one gets plunged. How will you save the things and how will our lives be saved?"

Kanu.—"Do not worry yourself over that. I have thought over the problem and hit upon a solution. I went to the fisherman Sambhu this evening and procured a strong rope from him. One end of the rope will be fixed to the trunk of a *Simul*-tree on the bank and the other end will be fixed to a raft made of banana-plants. I will loosen the rope in the middle and the raft will float behind our boat at some distance without attracting notice. When we shall have done our work, we will return home by means of the raft. We will plunder the jewellery and other things and with them plunge into the river, after having broken open the lower planks of the boat with an axe. The old Brahmin will verily shake his beard like a goat, while bidding adieu to the earth. In the meanti ne, we will drag the rope of the raft, so that in no time we shall be able to reach the bank. When the old woman and the still older man will breathe their last, who will be left there to help the detection of our deed? I will return the rope to Sambhu to-morrow. Well! there will end all matters and there will be none to whisper the grim tale of the night.

"The much desired-for property we will make over to our mothers; and then, dear Kanu, we shall, be placed far above want, and marry two fairies!"

Vashu and Kanu, in a firm attitude, left for Ganjer ghāt, determined to carry out the plan. They led the Brahmin-couple to the bank of the Brahmaputra. Whatever they had planned, they carried out fearlessly. The tragedy was duly enacted and then they returned home with the booty on the raft, being dragged to the bank by means of the rope.

When they returned home, just at that moment vultures shrieked overhead, ravens croaked and other birds and beasts proclaimed by their confused cries the advent of the morning.

Vashu knocked at the door and called out, "Oh mother, awake; Dawn's light is just peeping in. How long will you sleep? Now our misery is at an end; just come and see what I have got. You may now live at perfect ease. No more, mamma, will you have to shed tears, for having no food in the house for your son. Your days of tears and sorrow are over."

The mother, startled at her son's voice, rose from her bed and opened the door. In the meantime Vashu took the load from his head and handed it over to his mother. Vashu's mother said, "What is it that you have got? The contents, if they are food, cannot last for many days. How is it that you are vaunting about this small basket so much?" Vashu replied, "It is no food, mamma; open the basket and see that in it are stored things, which will supply us with food as long as we live." The old woman wonderingly opened the basket and was astonished to find the whole house, illuminated, as it were, by the riches contained in it. The sight struck her with surprise. There in the basket

were a number of *Beshars* (nose-ornaments), *jhumkas* (ear-rings) and various other ornaments of flower and fruit patterns, inlaid with precious stones. There were some precious necklaces, head-ornaments, beautiful gold-flowers for ears, also bracelets, lockets and garlands, strung with gold-flowers. There were nice pins and nose-ornaments, studded with pearls and diamonds. In one corner were observed about a hundred golden amulets and other ornaments of various patterns. There were, besides, belts with gold and silver pendants and beautiful *Gujris* for feet. Besides these, there were a large number of gold coins of the days of old emperors, bars of gold and silver of various sizes and golden cups and hair-combs of mica, of which the handles were solid gold. In a bundle lay valuable flame-coloured *Sadis*, which only ladies of the highest ranks wore.

Vashu's mother was wonder-struck, and, with gaping mouth, looked at her son and said, "What are all these things? How could you secure this property of a monarch?"

Then did Vashu relate the whole story from the beginning to the end, and as she heard it, Vashu's mother began to tremble in fear. She said in a sad tone, "What is it, Vashu, that you have done? You have killed a Brahmin, and know for certain that the curse that came out of his lips at the moment of his death will blast away all our future happiness. The lamp of our house will burn no more. There will be no children born in a house, cursed by a Brahmin, to light the evening lamp. If you were dead just after your birth, it would have been much better for me than to see you turn a robber. I sincerely wish now that you be drowned. Your death will indeed give me some relief."

She began to shed incessant tears. In the meantime Vashu took care to bury the treasure under ground. For the whole day Vashu's mother did not eat a single morsel of food, and, in great anger, did not speak to her son. When it dawned, her eyes appeared abnormally dull, sunk in their sockets; and a fever seized her, making her body dark as charcoal. For five or six days, she remained in her bed without any food and without speaking a word. The neighbours were full of sympathy and said, "Your mother has suffered much in her life. Try your best to place her under proper medical treatment."

Tinkari was a great physician in that locality. Vashu walked ten hours and reached his house. Vashu called on him and said in a hurry, "O doctor, my mother is passing through a great crisis. You must accompany me at once to my house." Tinkari, the physician, dressed himself decently and in the corner of his *chudder* tied some medicine. He took his long stick in hand and spread a big umbrella over his head. Before starting, he bowed to the sacred *Tulsi* plant in his house. The physician was of a dark complexion. His body seemed to have been polished by constantly rubbing oil over it. He had a flat nose and his whiskers were cut short. But his feet bore marks of sore on account of his having to walk along the uneven village-paths. His eyes were small and he looked around like a pigeon, as he walked. At times, he stumbled over the hard ground; but anyhow he reached Vashu's house in due time. Reaching the patient's house, the doctor said, "Only three pills, Vashu;—these will cure your mother, I assure you. To-day you are to give her bark of *bel* and *nim*-leaves, well boiled in water, to-morrow give her some spices boiled in hot water. On the third

day you are to give her that red pill, mixed with a few drops of country-wine, and the day after, you are to give her that blue pill with cold water, and on the day next, you are to administer the white one. This will bring her round, rest assured. When the fever subsides, give her a hot bath, and then she may be allowed to take rice of a very fine quality. But when you will give her the white pill, you must also give her the broth of tamarind to drink."

Vashu took the pills and the physician said, "Now I must depart." Vashu gave him one *kulâ* of rice and a basketful of pulses. From his orchard, he gathered some brinjals, chillies and bananas. He gave him, besides, some turmeric and salt and also a cupful of oil. The doctor was right glad, and smiling, left his house. In the evening of that day, Vashu's mother opened her eyes and looked at her son. That was her last and she left Vashu for ever and went straightway to the other world, whence her call had come.

(Ll. 1-112.)

(5)

Vashu took his mother's dead body on his shoulders and went to the river-ghat. There, in conformity with the usage of the Hindus, he first set fire to his mother's mouth and then floated the corpse in the stream. He then returned home and wept bitterly. In the whole world the barber-lad Vashu had none other than a mother to call his own and she, too, now left him for ever. Many a time did he lament, saying, "In this country, I will live no more. I must go to some foreign land. There I will live by begging from door to door. It is my crime that shocked my mother and thus caused her death. I cannot bear the stings of repentance. Grieving over her, I will give up this sinful body of mine."

For four or five days, he did not stir out but continually wept in his lonely room. Kanu and his mother visited his house frequently and tried to console him. By the healing influence of time, Vashu once more applied himself to his work. His occupation now became definitely settled. He used to kill the wayfarers by the blow of his long club and plunder whatever they possessed. Day and night Vashu and Kanu pursued this avocation, bound in brotherhood, and sometimes in the night, Vashu returned home, cooked his own meal, ate the same and went to bed in that lonely house.

On an auspicious day, fixed by astrologers, Kanu married a suitable bride and Kanu's mother now advised Vashu to be on the look out for a bride. "You burn your hands in cooking your own meals, my lad, and sometimes you have to live upon raw *chira*. You have been reduced to a skeleton and you know no peace of mind. About six miles from this place, there is a village called Mainda. There lives an honest man named Sadhu Sil. I have heard that he has got a real fairy in his daughter. Her name is Māniktārā. She is exquisitely handsome. Why not go to that village one day and open negotiations? And it may be that, by the grace of God, you will be happy by this marriage, if you can win her hands."

Being advised by Kanu's mother in this way, Vashu realised his situation and thought that it was a good advice. He resolved to go to Mainda the next morning. When it was morning, Vashu dressed himself decently. The day was very hot, it being the month of April. He covered his body with a *chudder* to protect it from the Sun, when he reached the village, it was about 2 P.M. He was perspiring and sorely feeling the heat. Close by, flowed a canal with transparent water in rapid

course. The women of the village came over there with their pitchers to carry water. On one side of the canal were rows of beautiful houses, but on the other side there was none. So Vashu sat under a *Simul*-tree. He breathed heavily and looked with thirsty eyes at the stream. He felt a desire to drink water, and so came down the landing-steps. Just at the time a maiden came from the other side. On her breast was a fine towel of green-coloured cotton and her hair was dishevelled, which waved playfully at her back. The hair was so long that it nearly touched her ankles. The coy maiden bent her eyes towards the earth and descended to the stream. She was quite unaware that Vashu was on the other side. Vashu, while drinking water, looked at her and felt as if a fairy had come down from the heaven. Vashu himself was a youth of handsome features and he felt love for the maiden at first sight. The girl, as she looked at him, became pleased with his handsome appearance. In her mind for the first time grew that passion, which, to maidenly souls was a novel experience, full of sweetness. Appeasing his thirst, Vashu the barber-lad, went back to the shade of the *Simul*-tree, but with crooked glance, looked again and again at the stream of Bailākhali. He reflected thus, "This girl is assuredly not a human being. She must be a nymph of heaven, I must try to know who she is." Thus resolved he addressed the maiden in a gentle voice and she was right glad at his words, standing on the other bank.

"Who are you, gentle maiden, all alone here, at this hour? Verily is your face like the moon. How beautiful do you look with sweats on your brow. The transparent water of the Bailākhali is playing with the flowing ends of your *Saḍi*. Your lovely figure

produces an ebb and flow in my blood. Your black hair is to be compared only with the black tip of the *Kuch*-fruit. Your lovely brows delight my eyes with their gentle curves. Your two black eyes throw their dart by sweet glances, which make a human being tremble as if shot by an arrow. How happy are you, O stream of Baliākhali! you seem to be so cheerful because you have got her sweet embrace. Thanks to this shade of the *Simul*-tree, from where I have obtained a glimpse of you. With sacred blades of grass and rice, I will worship you." Pausing for a few moments he again addressed the maiden, "You are not a fairy, nor a nymph, nor any spirit of the air. I have known you by your moon-like face. I remember to have seen you in the landing-ghat of the mart; and to-day I see you here in the stream of the Bailākhali. It now seems that my good luck has to-day given me my goddess, who is to adorn my house.

"Who are you, maiden, and whose daughter are you? You have cast your sweet glances upon me, which have made my head unsteady. I have lost my parents, I have lost my brothers and thus do I survive, —a wretched vagabond. I remember to have seen you some day in a mart near the *Ganjer-ghat*, and to-day you are here,—a piece of unparalleled good luck for me."

Māniktārā.

"All is done by the will of God. Human agencies are powerless. Though God has put you to a trial, that has not diminished, in the least, your worth in my eyes. Sometime ago, I went with my parents to your house. There I saw you in your room, though you did not notice me. Your mother treated me very kindly. She gave me *phul-bātāsā* (sugar-balls) with fried rice

of the *binni*-species. She also served me with curd of excellent quality. She took me kindly in her arms and said, "How happy would I be, if I could have you for my daughter-in-law!" My name is Māniktārā and my father's name is Sādhu Sil. If you are willing to have me, I do not think there will be any difficulty in your way."

Vashu.—"I do not know where your house stands on the other side of the canal. Will you point out the path leading to your house?"

Māniktārā.—"There is a ferry there on the eastern side of the canal. On crossing it, you will find a temple dedicated to the Goddess Chandi. That temple and the lands, adjoining to the same, belong to my father."

Māniktārā remained in the bathing-ghat and Vashu hurried towards her home. Reaching there, he called out, "Who is there in the house? May I come in?" Sādhu Sil had just finished his bath. He came out at the voice of a stranger and young Vashu saluted him, when he came near. Sādhu said, "You do not seem to be known to me. Who are you, young man? Where is your home and what is your father's name?"

"My house," said Vashu, "is at the village Ganjer-ghat. My father was Vishu Sil. But my mother and brothers are all dead." Sādhu recognised him after this introduction. He spread a mat in the temple-compound and showed him a warm hospitality. He entered the inner apartments and said to his wife, "The son of Vishu Sil is at our house. I do not know what may be the object of his visit." The good wife said, "Could you not learn why he has come?" "I have not asked that yet," replied Sādhu.

With a pillow in his hand, meant for the repose of his guest, did Sadhu Sil come near Vashu again and ask him the object of his kind visit to his house.

Vashu bent his eyes towards the ground and in a voice half-choked by shame, delivered himself thus, "You know, Sir, that there is none in my house now. All are dead and gone. This is just the time when I should seek for a suitable bride to look after my household. I have come out in search of one, who would take charge of my household. I have heard that you have got a marriageable daughter. I have made myself bold enough to approach you with the proposal. If you would kindly approve of it, I shall be a slave to you all my life."

Sādhu was right glad at his heart at the proposal and went into the inner apartments to discuss the matter with his wife. He smilingly said to his wife, "Mānik-tārā's bridegroom is there in our temple-compound." She replied, "It is a very good proposal. Now make arrangements to entertain him suitably (*lit.* to kindle the hearth)." Sādhu Sil had three sons, but none of them was present at that time. All of them had gone out for fishing. So the old man was in some difficulty. The mistress of the house ordered her second daughter-in-law to cook and the two others were required to do sundry things. "It is nearly noon-tide, already late. Send him some oil for bath." Saying this, the old woman began to look after other things.

Vashu rubbed oil over his body and went to the river for bathing. The second daughter-in-law was cooking and the other two were helping her in the necessary preparations. Just at this moment the eldest son returned home with a big *Rui*-fish in his hand. The second son also appeared shortly after, with some *koi*, *puthi*, *khalishā* and other small fishes. Next came the third son with a basket, full of vegetables, especially one big *chai*-plant. Vashu now came back from the river-ghat and was served with the kernel of cocoanut, fried

rice, molasses, sugar-balls and other confectionaries, such as *chirār-moā* and *tiler lāru*. He was, besides, served with the *doa*-fruit, bananas and a cup, full of sweet milk with some sugar. This was light refreshment, which Vashu partook of with avidity and then took a midday-nap in the temple-compound.

The second daughter-in-law was busy preparing the soup of pulses and the male members of the household grew impatient at the delay in preparation. Her brothers-in-law, the younger and elder ones, went to take their bath; but when they returned home after finishing bath, they could not be pleased with what they saw. For, their sister-in-law was still busy with a fork, trying to dissolve the pulses in the hot water; the soup had not yet been prepared. The eldest son's wife sat over the kitchen-knife, dressing the fish; while the youngest of the three wives hurried to the pond to wash the rice. To add to the confusion, the eldest daughter-in-law sustained a wound in her finger from the prickly bone of a *singi*-fish. The mother-in-law administered pepper-paste to the wound. It was midday; but the soup of pulses was not yet ready, and as such, how could it be offered to the bridegroom-elect? The second daughter-in-law, in utter confusion, diligently applied the fork to the yet unboiled pulse-soup for dissolving the peas; and a sound was thus generated, resembling the rattle of a spinning-wheel. Everybody became impatient with hunger. The elder brother-in-law was grumbling over the delay, the younger one was muttering out his discontent; while the old father-in-law sat in greedy expectation,—spotted, like a tiger, all over his body, with sandal-marks. All were dying in hunger, as it were; the husband (the second son) in a rage, rushed into the kitchen and caught his wife by the forelocks. The

mother came to the rescue of the daughter-in-law and delivered her from the rude grip of the infuriated son. She then gave her three sons water to drink. The pulse-soup was ready in the meantime, and so was the fish-curry, too, though prepared in a hurry. Seats were spread on the floor of the spacious dining-chamber. The old man of the house, together with Vashu and the three sons, sat on the seats, assigned to them, to eat their dinner. Five plates were placed before the five men. But Sādhu's eyes waxed red in anger, as he looked at the plate that had been offered to Vashu. The old man howled out his strong disapproval of the conduct of the old mistress and the daughters-in-law. "Being women, you do not know the rules of domestic discipline. By your unworthy conduct you will bring about the ruin of my household. My daughter is matchless, all points considered and every virtue reckoned; and you, ignorant hags, have conspired to blast her fortune. What stupidity, first to offer fried fish to a son-in-law! Have you considered the evil that would follow from your conduct? The effect is that the son-in-law becomes half-dead in his father-in-law's house. (Other) sons-in-law taunt him, the mother-in-law maligns, the sisters-in-law torture, and the brothers-in-law despise the poor fellow." [1]

At these words, the guilty matron took the plate in her hand and removed all fried and roasted items of food. Vashu, however, felt it to be a loss, thus to be deprived of the big fried fishes of the *Koi*-species, roasted brinjals, fried potatoes, sesamum-balls, the toasted *ulkis*, flavoured with the paste of split peas and also the overdone *chápati*.

[1] This superstitious belief is still current among the rustic folk of some districts of Eastern Bengal.

"I got the delicacies," he mused within himself, "exactly to my liking, but have been forbidden to take them. This, however, augurs the intended matrimony and makes me glad at heart."

Pulse-soup, prepared in combination with fish-heads and herbs of the Bâlai-species, was next served in a good quantity by the youngest daughter-in-law. She also served the *Suktâ* (a sort of slightly bitter vegetable condiment) and the preparation of gourd. She then gave the dried sauce of *khalisha* and *puthi* fishes and also a cupful of half-boiled pulse-soup, prepared with *Mâsha*-peas. Vashu, however, did not take the last-named item, which remained as it was, full in the cup. But another cup, containing the *muga*-soup, prepared in combination with the flavorous heads and bones of Boāl-fish, Vashu emptied over his plate. Another cup, filled with the soup of Boāl-fish, was also served, but this was not much relished on account of its pungency. The broth of Rui-fish, however, together with five pieces of soft fish, was tasted with good appetite. The *murighanta*—a preparation with the head of Rui-fish beaten into fine pieces with a pestle—Vashu smilingly partook of, and in greedy appreciation of the flavour, he ate up the last grain of rice from his plate. The sour gruel of unripe *āmni* was next served, which Vashu sipped up in the fashion of drinking water. A cupful of sweet milk and another cupful of curd were then relished with fried corn (*khai*).

Sādhu became pleased to witness the appetite with which Vashu relished the dinner. Sadhu became thus resolved, "I will give my daughter in marriage to this youth. This is my intent. May the youth be granted a long life! Let the will of God be fulfilled. But I will not disclose anything now."

Dinner finished, the five men left their seats and went to wash their face. Sādhu then, together with his three sons, repaired to the drawing room adjacent to the temple; and when all had seated themselves at ease, Sādhu Sil spoke to Vashu in a soft and slow voice, "Hear me, Vashu, my girl is possessed of all maidenly virtues. She performs all the household duties, inside and outside, with a neatness and dexterity, which would surprise the male members of any house; and there in the sphere of her activities, she would not brook any intermeddling—she must do everything herself. She is verily a paragon of beauty, and the thought, that is indeed uppermost in my mind now, is that of seeking out a suitable groom for her. Who knows what has been decreed by Providence? You see, the difficulty about you is this, that your parents are, neither of them, alive, and as such, how can we entrust our treasure—the very moon on earth—to your care? Whose help will she count upon in your house and who will be her help-mate in restoring order to your household? When, at night, you may be off, rowing your boats in the river, Māniktārā will be all alone in your house and this thought makes me particularly anxious."

But the three sons of Sādhu Sil had already conceived a liking for the youth. They said to their father, "Why, father, what makes you vacillating still? Our eldest sister Panchā is a widow. She is, besides, perplexed with the problem of procuring her bread." Vashu gladly approved of the idea of taking this lady to his house and promised to maintain her as long as she would live. This assurance from Vashu encouraged the old man and he gave something like a half-assent to the proposal. The three daughters-in-law expressed their consent and the mother, too, could not but approve of the proposed matrimony.

The date of celebrating the marriage was fixed sometime early in *Baisakh*. Fried paddy with sweet milk formed the evening-repast of Vashu. And glad at heart, Vashu then donned his *dhuti* and *chudder* and proceeded homewards. (Ll. 1-250.)

(6)

Astrologers were next consulted by Sādhu and an auspicious date was fixed. As for the rest, namely, the future of the match, they could not have any fore-glimpse of that. Fate alone would determine it. The fifth day of *Baisakh* was fixed and Sādhu Sil, with the help of his three sons, set about preparing themselves for the occasion. A toll of three hundred rupees was exacted by Sādhu Sil from his son-in-law, and the celebration duly took place on the 5th of *Baisakh*. The night of marriage was spent in high glee, amidst the festive songs and merry-makings of the three wives of the three brothers and other girls of the village; and on the day following, the customary social banquet was provided.

Vashu started homewards in company with the bride, Māniktārā. While parting, Māniktārā spoke to her mother, "Do not forget, mother, to send for sister Pancha. Her absence on the occasion of farewell-greetings makes me sad at heart. When she will be here, ask her to go to me." On the eve of their departure, Vashu and Māniktārā stood before their superiors; the ladies of the house blessed them with offerings of sacred grass and paddy. The mother, too, pronounced her benedictions, wishing the couple long life and unbroken happiness. She also said to her daughter, "You will be alone there my child, do not neglect your health." Māniktārā shed silent tears; she had no speech to suit the occasion.

"Grieve not, mother; should God keep me safe and sound, I shall return to your arms," she delivered herself in these few words. The mother then stood before Tārā, and performed certain rites which would have the effect of making her beloved of her husband and then threw away a quantity of dust from the hole of a mouse, an observance which symbolises the daughter's formal absolution from the debt she owed to her mother for her sustenance and upbringing.

The poet Shekh Jamatulla enjoys the fun and smilingly remarks, "What would this formality avail? It is a puerile idea. Every single drop of milk, sucked from the mother's breast, binds the child fast in a profound debt of affection and gratitude, which nobody on earth can repay. The scriptures of the Hindus are authoritative indeed. But is this idea very commendable, namely that parental debt may be repaid by means of the gift of a quantity of dust from a rat's hole?"

(Ll. 1-30.)

(7)

Vashu arrived, with his young bride, at Ganjerghat. Not being attended by any procession or party, they entered their house and seated themselves on a bedstead. In the meantime, Kanu's mother arrived there, and Kanu, himself, came, followed by other relatives and neighbours. The wives of the fishermen, too, came there to have a look at the bride, and their object fulfilled, they went away, remarking that the union of the two was suitable and would prove happy and peaceful.

A day passed; another rolled by and thus a fortnight wore away; and Vashu Sil did not, for a day, stir out of his house, leaving his lovely bride alone. One day finishing his mid-day meal, Vashu retired to the shade of an